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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' attending a function organised by Chinese Embassy in Kathmandu on the occasion of Chinese New Year in the capital on Sunday.

PM leading Nepali team to Uganda NAM summit

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' is leaving for Kampala, the Republic of Uganda, on January 18, leading a Nepali delegation to the 19th Summit of Heads of State and Government of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) being held there from January 19 to 20.

The Prime Minister will be accompanied by his daughter Ganga Dahal, according to a statement issued by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs on Sunday.

The Nepali delegation includes Minister for Foreign Affairs Narayan Prakash Saud, Foreign Secretary Sewa Lamsal and senior officials of the Government of Nepal.

The Prime Minister is scheduled to address the plenary session of the Summit on the theme 'Deepening Cooperation for Shared Global Affluence' on January 19.

On the same day, the Prime Minister will attend the state banquet hosted by the President of the Republic of Uganda, Gen. Yoweri Kaguta Museveni, in honour of the heads of the delegation of NAM Member States.

In the margins of the Summit, Prime Minister Prachanda will have bilateral meetings with heads of state, heads of government and other high dignitaries attending the Summit, read the statement of the Ministry.

The Summit will be preceded by the Ministerial Meeting on January 17-18.

Foreign Minister Saud will leave Kathmandu on January 16, leading a Nepali delegation to the Ministerial meeting of the Summit. The Ministerial Meeting will be preceded by the Senior Officials Meeting on January 15-16.

The Summit will consider the report of the Preparatory Ministerial Meeting, review the progress achieved in the implementation of the outcomes of the 18th Summit held in 2019, and conclude with the adoption of the Kampala Declaration.

Nepal is a founding member of the Non-Aligned Movement and has been actively participating in all NAM Summits since its inception. Principles of non-alignment constitute one of the basic tenets of Nepal's foreign policy.

The Prime Minister will return to Kathmandu on January 21.

After the 19th NAM Summit, the Third South Summit is being held in Kampala from January 21 to 22. Foreign Secretary Sewa Lamsal will lead the Nepali delegation to the South Summit, according to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs

NEPAL IS COMMITTED TO ONE CHINA PRINCIPLE: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' said on Sunday that Nepal has a clear point of view regarding 'Taiwan independence' that the island is an integral part of China.

"This has been clarified in the joint statement issued during my visit to China. We want to say again that we are against Taiwan independence," he said while inaugurating the Chinese New Year in Kathmandu.

> Relations between the two countries are strong based on the principles of peaceful coexistence and Panchasheel.

Stating that Nepal and China are close neighbours and trusted friends, PM Prachanda said that the relations between the two countries are strong based on the principles of peaceful coexistence and Panchasheel.

"Nepal is committed to the One China principle. Our commitment in this regard is clear and firm. Changes in internal and external affairs will not affect our commitment in any way," he said.

Making it clear that Nepali land will not be used against China, he said that the civilisations of the two countries are connected not only by rivers and snow chains, but also by common culture and people-level relations.

Govt decides to pay Rs. 8.1bn to contractors

Builders seek payment of additional Rs. 40bn

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Amidst discouraging performance of the development budget, the government decided on Sunday to immediately clear the remaining payments of the public infrastructure construction to the contractors. It has announced that the clearing of the dues would begin with Rs. 1.71 billion government liability from the last Fiscal Year 2022/23 and Rs. 6.30 billion of this year.

The government could spend only 15.52 per cent of the total capital allocation for the current fiscal year so far. By Saturday, it mobilised Rs. 46.88 billion of the total development budget Rs. 302.07 billion, according to the statistics of the Financial Comptroller General Office (FCGO).

A meeting called by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and attended by Minister for Finance, Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat, Minister for Physical Planning and Transport, Prakash Jwala, Chief Secretary, Dr. Baikuntha Aryal, Finance Secretary Dr. Krishna Hari Pushkar, Secretary of the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport, Keshav Kumar Sharma, Director General of the Department Roads, Sushil Babu Dhakal, at the Prime Minister's Office decided to proceed with the payment process on Sunday.

> PM Prachanda directed the Ministry of Finance (MoF) to speed up the development works by disbursing Rs. 8.1 billion immediately. With this decision, the government has expected that development and construction work will accelerate and the economy will become more dynamic.

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However, the Federation of Contractors Associations of Nepal (FCAN) said that the amount the government announced to pay soon was the dues from the last fiscal while the contractors are asking the government to facilitate the remaining payment of Rs. 40 billion which is pending.

Contrary to the government's claim, President of FCAN, Rabi Singh, said that Rs. 6.30 billion was not the liability created for the government in the current fiscal year but it was the amount from the bills submitted to the government in the last fiscal and the budget was allocated this year.

He said that the contractors couldn't meet the 30 per cent milestone set by the government for the last fiscal year (ending mid-July) due to the ban on crusher industries and elections. "Therefore, we had asked the concerned ministries and Prime Minister for the extension of the deadline. The government has expressed its consent to the potential extension but it couldn't be implemented," said Singh.

According to the builders, they have been demanding for time extension of at least six months to one year. They had held discussions with PM Prachanda regarding it.

Singh said that the ministries couldn't implement the decision of the government fearing that it would attract the attention of the Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA). The FCAN has suggested them either to implement the decision or correct it so that there would be no abuse of authority.

The delay in the construction of public infrastructure has troubled both the contractors and the public, said Singh.

If all the dues are cleared including those claimed by the contractors, capital budget absorption would reach 30 per cent.

Local govt, community should work to resolve human-animal conflict: DPM Khadka

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka has said that the conflict between humans and animals is increasing in Bardiya and that the local community and all three levels of government should work together to solve the problem.

Inaugurating the Bansgadhi Industrial Trade Fair on Sunday, DPM Khadka said that with the development of the national park area, wildlife has increased in this area and when wild animals come out of the national park in search of proper habitat and food species, human life is in danger and crops have also been damaged. According to him, the federal government is also serious about solving the recurring problem.

He said that the construction of national pride projects including irrigation in Bardiya, which is the grain storehouse of Lumbini Province, should be completed soon and radical changes should be brought in the agricultural sector.

The locals cannot get as much benefit as they work here from the agriculture sector as there is lack of chemical fertilizers, inadequacy of irrigation on arable land, lack of proper training for farmers and inability to use modern technology and methods in agriculture, Deputy Prime Minister Khadka said.

Provinces and the local governments should implement the programme in such a way that the level helps in the modernisation and commercialisation of agriculture of this area, he said.

DPM Khadka asked the industrialists not to be disappointed saying that the economy is starting to improve.

He expressed his belief that the festival will help promote the tourism industry by promoting the religious and touristic sectors of the region and developing internal and external tourism.

DPM Khadka said that such festival will also motivate the homestays run at the local level to be more organised.

He said that although there was a delay in the formulation of some laws to be made by the federal government, the government is preparing to make the necessary federal laws in the coming session of the House.

Deputy Prime Minister Khadka emphasised that even though political parties compete in elections having differences in beliefs and opinions, everyone should be on the same ground and understanding in matters of development issue.

Seven ruling parties appeal to vote for common candidates

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Seven leaders including Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' of the ruling coalition parties have appealed to all the voters of the National Assembly election to cast their votes in favour of the common candidates of the ruling parties.

» NA ELECTION

A joint appeal issued by the chairpersons of seven ruling parties on Sunday read that the present ruling coalition was formed to safeguard the constitution and consolidate the democratic republic system.

"Our common goal is to attain sustainable peace, good governance, development, prosperity and social justice in the country," the top leaders said in their appeal.

They further said that political stability was the pre-condition for the development of the country. They further said, "We are committed to consolidating democratic republic system, political stability, sustainable peace, good governance and prosperity, and we promise to be always active with honesty to these commitments."

Prime Minister and CPN (Maoist Centre) chairman Prachanda, Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba, CPN (Unified Socialist) chairman Madhav Kumar Nepal, Janata Samajwadi Party-Nepal chairperson Upendra Kumar Yadav, Nagarik Unmukti Party Nepal chairperson Ranjita Shrestha Chaudhary, Loktantrik Samajwadi Party chairperson Mahanta Thakur and Rastriya Janamorcha chairperson Chitra Bahadur KC jointly signed the appeal letter.

They further said that the NA election was an opportunity to further ensure political stability in the country by strengthening the present coalition.

They also included the names of all common candidates from the ruling coalition asking voters to cast their votes for them.

» SEE PAGE 6

Tharus celebrating Maghi festival with fanfare

BY ABINASH CHAUDHARI/SIRAJ KHAN
Dhangadhi, Jan. 14



The winter is at its peak with fog and cold waves across the Tarai. Amid the bone-chilling cold, the Tharu settlements of the southern plain have become vibrant with traditional dances and songs. From the children to the elderly, all are enjoying the Maghi festival, their annual festival.

Maghi, the great festival for the Tharu community has made the Tharus, the indigenous people of the Tarai, enthusiastic, as they are set to celebrate their festival, which is also the new year day for them.

The Tharu settlements are alive with Maghauta dance, Dhamar and Dhumru songs. Draupati Chaudhary, a resident of Bhada Village of Dhangadhi Sub-Metropolitan City-16, said that the traditional Maghauta dance brightened her village.

In the Tharu community, it is customary to celebrate the Maghi festival with much fanfare from the last day of Poush month to the second day of Magh month. On the first day, it is celebrated 'Jita Marne' in the morning, and delicious pork dishes are cooked.

The first day of Magh is the last day of Tharu Sambat, there is a tradition to celebrate this day forgetting all the sufferings of the whole year.

Magh 1 marks the beginning of the New Year for the Tharu community. Tharu Sambat 2647 will start on Monday. On this day, people of this community wake up early in the morning and take holy baths in nearby rivers, ponds and streams and take blessings from the elders.

People exchange greetings forgetting anger and jealousy and they eat meat, Dhikri, yam and other varieties of food.

The last day of the festival is called 'Khojnibojni'. On this day, the previous financial year is reviewed and plans are made for the new year. Similarly, there is a tradition of selecting the leader of the village on this day.

Magh is also a festival of independence for the Tharu community. Before the abolition of Kamaya system, Kamaiya and Kamalhari used to change the owner's house only during the Maghi festival.

Bismati Devi Chaudhary of Vani Mukta Kamaiya Settlement of Krishnapur Municipality-2 said that the festival is celebrated as a festival of freedom as a new chapter is believed to start in the life of Free Kamaiya and Kamalhari since Magh.

After Maghi festival, marriage, construction of new houses and other works begin in the Tharu community. According to Tharu leader Dil Bahadur Chaudhary, Magh is a festival of religious, cultural, social and economic importance.

Similarly, In Nepalgunj, the Tharu-dominated villages of Banke and Bardiya have now become vibrant with the arrival of the festival.

Ram Lakhan Tharu, ward chair of Raptisonari Rural Municipality-7 in Banke, said that the festival of Maghi, which is celebrated as the New Year by the Tharu community, started in the villages a week ago.

He said that this festival is celebrated by the Tharu community as Badka Tauhar (big festival) festival. People who did not go home during the Dashain and Tihar have also returned home to celebrate Maghi.

Securities worth Rs.54.76 billion listed at NEPSE in five months

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14



Securities worth Rs. 54.76 billion were listed at NEPSE during the first five months of the current fiscal year 2023/24. Such securities comprise ordinary shares worth Rs. 44.65 billion, right shares worth Rs. 6.10 billion, bonus shares worth Rs. 3.98 billion and FPO worth Rs. 30.23 million, according to a current macroeconomic and financial report of Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB).

Securities Board of Nepal (SEBON) approved the total public issuance of securities worth Rs. 16.51 billion in the review period which includes ordinary shares worth Rs. 8.51 billion, debentures worth Rs. 4.40 billion, mutual funds worth Rs.2.50 billion, and right shares worth Rs.1.10 billion.

The paid-up value of 7.93 billion shares listed at NEPSE stood Rs. 786.25 billion in mid-December 2023. The share of BFIs and insurance companies in stock market capitalization is 62.3 per cent in mid-December 2023.

Such a share for hydropower companies is 13.5 per cent, investment companies 7.2 per cent, manufacturing and processing industries 5 per cent, hotels 3.2 per cent, trading companies 0.5 per cent and the shares of other companies is 8.3 per cent, said the report. Number of companies listed at NEPSE reached 267 in mid-December 2023.

Out of the total listing, 134 are Bank and Financial Institutions (BFIs) and insurance companies, 89 hydropower companies, 21 manufacturing and processing industries, 7 hotels, 7 investment companies, 4 trading companies and 5 others. The number of companies listed at NEPSE was 247 in mid-December 2022.

The NEPSE index stood at 1994.60 in mid-December 2023 compared to 1882.61 in mid-December 2022.

The stock market capitalization in mid-December 2023 stood Rs. 3076.52 billion compared to Rs. 2721.11 billion in mid-December 2022.

Nepal-India inter-governmental session on trade, transit held

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Nepal-India Inter-Governmental Sub-Committee (IGSC) on Trade, Transit and Cooperation to Combat Unauthorised Trade convened its latest session in Kathmandu on Friday and Saturday.

In the meeting, Ram Chandra Tiwari, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies led the Nepali side while Shri Vipul Bansal, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Commerce, Government of India, led the Indian delegation.

Senior officials from various ministries and the Embassy of India in Kathmandu, and key representatives from different Nepali ministries and departments attended the meeting, the Embassy of India said in a statement on Sunday. This meeting of the IGSC, a bilateral mechanism aimed at bolstering trade and investment ties, witnessed comprehensive discussions on a range of significant issues.

"Both sides discussed mutual market access for pharmaceuticals and Ayurvedic products. The Indian side highlighted the need for an IPR regime in accordance with the provisions of the Paris Convention for encouraging FDI," read the statement.

The agenda also covered discussions on the review of the Treaty of Transit and the Treaty of Trade, proposed amendments to existing agreements, strategies for enhancing investment, the harmonization of standards and the synchronized development of trade infrastructure.

One of the highlights of the meeting, according to the statement, was the focus on bilateral initiatives aimed at further strengthening the seamless cross-border connectivity between India and Nepal including through the construction of new Integrated Check Posts and railway links. Both sides expressed a commitment to implementing these initiatives, reflecting the shared vision of prosperous bilateral trade.

Indushankar Sugar Mills pays Rs. 170 M to sugarcane farmers

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sarlahi, Jan. 14

Indushankar Sugar Mills, Hariwan, which started sugarcane crushing three weeks ago, has paid Rs. 170 million to the farmers. According to the price of sugarcane fixed by the government, the industry has already paid Rs. 170 million to the farmers, said Thakur Nepal, administrative chief of the industry.

The government has fixed the price of sugarcane at Rs. 635 per quintal this year. Out of this, the sugar industry has to pay Rs. 565 per quintal and the government will provide Rs. 70 as a subsidy.

Indushankar, which has been paying to the sugarcane farmers in time every year, has also deposited the money in the sugarcane farmers' accounts at intervals of 10 days to two weeks. Indushankar started sugarcane crushing from December 22, 2023.

Nepal said that the industry has crushed 764,700 quintals of sugarcane so far. According to him, the industry has set a target of crushing 3.5 million quintals of sugarcane this year. Due to the agitation of sugarcane farmers, the industry started crashing canes after some delay.

Farmers are now bringing sugarcane to the mill by taking permits to bring canes from the industry. The tractors and trucks and carts carrying sugarcane can be seen everywhere on the interior roads, including the East-West highway.

Out of the three sugar industries in the district, Indushankar Sugar Mills, Hariwan and Mahalaxmi Sugar Industry, Bagdaha are operational, but Annapurna Sugar Industry, Dhankaul has not been operational so far this year.

Devendra Yadav, President of Godaita Sugarcane Farmers' Association and Mayor of Godaita Municipality, said that the Mahalaxmi Sugar Industry, Bagdaha has improved the payment of farmers this year compared to the past. He expressed his happiness that farmers are getting payment within 10 to 15 days from the sugarcane crushing industry.

Gas plant meets hurdles in lack of enough waste



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Ghorahi, Jan. 14

As per the plan to produce gas from waste and supply it to households, a gas plant has been established in Ghorahi, but due to lack of waste, there has been a problem in its operation.

Despite beginning to produce gas from waste and distributing it to houses through pipes in Ghorahi Sub-Metropolitan City-16, Karautidanda from last year, the gas plant could not be fully operational.

Harisharan Shrestha, plant manager of Nepal Energy Development Company, said that the gas plant needs 25 tonnes of waste daily for its full operation, but now only 400 kg to 500 kg of waste is available. Despite all the preparations, the plant could not be fully operational due to the lack of waste, he said.

Shrestha said that the gas produced from waste is being distributed through pipes to only 34 houses in Ghorahi Sub-Metropolitan City-16, Garuwagaun.

According to him, 60 to 65 cubic meters of gas is produced daily.

He said that when the gas plant is fully operational, about 2,000 cubic meters of gas can be produced daily. He said that if there is a lot of waste, the production will increase and there are preparations to distribute the gas according to the plan.

According to him, in the first phase, they have a plan to supply gas to 750 households, but he said that there is a problem in distributing it. He said, "For gas production, there is a problem in getting the waste and cow dung. As a result, there is a problem in supplying gas to consumers."

He said that despite reaching to different areas of the district for waste, there is a problem in getting it.

He said, "Initially, it was thought that it would be enough because there is a lot of garbage in Ghorahi.

But now there is a problem to get enough garbage. Even after talking to other municipalities, we have not been able to get it."

A tripartite agreement to produce gas from waste in Ghorahi was made between Alternative Energy Promotion Centre, Nepal Energy Development Company and Ghorahi Sub-Metropolitan City on November 21, 2018.

According to the agreement, it was decided that the Sub-Metropolitan City would provide land and Nepal Energy Development Company would invest 60 per cent and the Alternative Energy Promotion Centre would invest 40 per cent to operate the plant for the production of gas from waste. So far, more than Rs. 200 million has been spent for gas production from waste.

As per the agreement, the Ghorahi Sub-Metropolitan City has provided about three bighas of land for gas production. Laxman Adhikari, chief of Environment and Sanitation Section of Ghorahi Sub-Metropolitan City, said that there was a problem in the collection of waste required for industry due to the consumers not separating degradable and non-degradable waste.

Nepalgunj Sub-Metropolitan City meets 54% of revenue target in first half

RSS
Khajura (Banke), Jan. 14

In the first half of the current fiscal year, the Nepalgunj Sub-Metropolitan City has achieved 54 percent of its annual revenue target.

The local government in Lumbini Province had set a target of collecting internal revenues amounting to Rs 190 million for the fiscal year, and as of now, Rs 102.07 million has been collected. This information was shared during the 14th Convention of the Sub-metropolis Municipal Assembly, which concluded on Saturday.

Mayor Prashant Bista presented various agendas during the event, seeking approvals for plans for the current fiscal year, budget transfers, additional projects under the Prime Minister's Employment Programme, public-private partnerships for waste management, and regulations for tobacco products in the town.

All proposed agendas were unanimously passed during the convention, according to Chief Administrative Officer Om Bahadur Khadka. The event was attended by ward chairs from all 23 wards, municipal executive assembly members, and local government employees.

According to the Deputy Mayor, the sub-metropolis has made financial progress of 32.7 per cent towards recurrent expenditure, of 13.42 per cent towards capital expenditure and of 43.81 per cent towards financial management.

Likewise, it is stated in the progress report that provisions have been made for direct payment to the related bank account through the EFT system with the objective of making the payment process smooth and transparent and that so far 250 persons have benefited from the 24-hour free ambulance service from home to hospital.

Among other works mentioned in the progress report include: design and implementation of local curriculum, promotion of IT-friendly teaching and learning, conduction of continuous campaign for the sustainability of the Sub-metropolis as the child marriage-free sub-metropolis, monitoring of cooperatives, market monitoring, distribution of the social security allowances through the EFT and the operation of the weekly evening-time Maha Aarati rituals at Bageshwori Temple premises with support from the Sub-metropolis.

Also included in the progress report are activities like the regular cleaning of the main roads in the city, the management of medical waste in an effective manner, conduction of various disaster prevention drills at ward number 3 and 7, retrofitting of the vulnerable physical infrastructures and the formulation of several guidelines and policies related to public service.

DEATH TOLL RISES TO 13 IN CHINA COAL MINE ACCIDENT

AP
Beijing, Jan.14

The death toll has risen to 13 in a coal mine accident in central China, state media said Sunday.

Three people remain missing after Friday's accident in the city of Pingdingshan in Henan Province, the official Xinhua News Agency said, citing the owner of the mine.

Preliminary investigation indicates the cause was a coal and gas explosion, Xinhua said.

China had a series of fatal coal mine accidents last year despite efforts to improve mine safety.

Coal remains a major source of electricity in the country, even as China far outpaces the rest of the world in installing solar and wind facilities to combat climate change.

Wildfire prevention top agenda for Hawaii

AP
Honolulu, Jan.14

Hawaii lawmakers are due to convene this week for the first time since the burning of historic Lahaina awakened the state to the deadly and costly threat posed by wildfires in an age of climate change.

The tragedy refocused the attention of lawmakers. Now, fighting and preventing wildfires and helping the island of Maui recover from the flames top the agenda as Hawaii's Legislature returns for a new session this week.

"It really kicked us into gear in a different way," said state Rep. Nadine Nakamura, the House majority leader and a Democrat.

The Aug. 8 blaze killed 100 people, destroyed more than 2,000 buildings and displaced 12,000 people. Experts estimate it will cost $5.5 billion to replace the structures exposed to the fire.

Investigators are still studying how the fire began. Heavy winds whipped up by a powerful hurricane passing south of Hawaii helped the flames spread quickly, as did drought and non-native fire-prone grasses. Another fire in early August burned about 20 homes in Kula, a town on the slopes of Haleakala volcano. House Democrats will look at wildfire prevention needs statewide and develop an understanding of what the state Department of Land and Natural Resources needs in order to do a better job, Nakamura said.

A House wildfire prevention working group formed after the fire recommended a range of new measures, including a public awareness campaign to prevent fires from starting and tax or insurance incentives for wildfire-safe structures.

The working group recommended that the state maintain firefighting aircraft and other equipment specifically to fight wildfires.

The Senate majority said in a news release it was committed to forming a fire risk task force and seeking permanent funding for the Hawaii Wildfire Management Organization, which is a hub for wildfire prevention and mitigation.

Democrats have overwhelming majorities in both chambers, controlling 44 out of 50 seats in the House (one seat is vacant) and 23 out of 25 seats in the Senate.

Gov. Josh Green, a Democrat, in December asked lawmakers to appropriate $425 million for the Maui cleanup and emergency housing, and millions more to reduce statewide wildfire risk.

Colin Moore, a University of Hawaii political science professor, said it was clear after Lahaina that state agencies need more money to manage forests and other natural resources.

That could help revive a proposal considered last year to charge visitors for a yearlong pass to visit state parks and trails.

The bill would be popular during an election year, Moore said. "That is the sort of thing legislators will want to advertise in their reelection campaigns," he said. Nakamura said the Maui fires exacerbated a problem that existed long before: the proliferation of vacation rentals around the state.

Thousands of Lahaina residents who lost their homes in the fire are still living in hotels five months after the blaze because there is not enough housing for them, even though tourists are renting condos in their midst. Many wildfire evacuees have left Maui because they can't find a place to live.

Lawmakers could revisit legislation that has failed before that would give counties the authority to phase out short-term rentals, Nakamura said.

A University of Hawaii analysis estimates vacation rentals account for 15% of Maui's housing stock. In Lahaina, the ratio is 40%.

Moore expects lawmakers to continue to try to address one of Hawaii's most persistent challenges: the statewide housing shortage and high cost of housing that is fueling an exodus of Native Hawaiians and other local-born residents from the state. But any measures would likely be "reforms on the margins" instead of dramatic overhauls, he said.

"I think you're going to see more of what we've seen in the past, which is trying to figure out what is the right mix of regulatory reforms and subsidies and rental assistance," Moore said.

He said people needing affordable housing the most are a large, unorganized group that has little pull at the Legislature. Groups who care passionately about regulations restricting or slowing housing construction — for example, rules governing historic preservation or environmental regulation — are more readily able to mobilize and advocate, he said.

BHAKTAPUR CHAMBER GETS FIRST FEMALE PRESIDENT

RSS
Bhaktapur, Jan. 14

Roshani Maiya Dhaubanja has been unanimously elected as the President of the Bhaktapur Chamber of Commerce and Industry during its 36th Annual General Meeting and Convention-2024. Previously serving as the senior vice president, Dhaubanja's election marks a historic moment, as she becomes the first female president in the Chamber's 57-year-old history.

The newly elected 24-member working committee, led by Dhaubanja, includes Krishna Murari Neupane (senior vice president), Ganesh Hari Prajapati (vice president), Rajendra Prasad Prajapati (vice president-commodity), Dinesh Gosai (vice president-associate), Nabin Prajapati (general secretary), Sachindra Pradhananga (secretary), and Bishwaram Duwal (treasurer), according to election committee coordinator advocate Gajendra Shankar Timila.

Maghe Sankranti fair begins in Devghat

BY BASANTA PARAJULI
Narayangadh, Jan. 14

Maghe Sankranti Fair began at Devghat by performing a puja and erecting a bamboo with 'Om' sign in Devghat on Sunday. Galeshwor Ashram's pithadhis Swami Aatmananda Giri, Harihar Ashram's pithadhis Swami Gyanananda Saraswoti and Mahesh Sanyas Ashram's pithadhis Ramanananda Giri accompanied by devotees gathered at the Galeshwor Ashram placed the bamboo in the river which also included a traditional musical procession.

Swami Aatmananda Giri said that placing the bamboo in the river was a traditional ritual and such rituals connected to the originality and culture of Devghat should be promoted.

He said, "The religious and cultural significance of Devghat is linked with Maghe Sankranti. The confluence of the Trishuli and the Kaligandaki rivers, originating from Damodar Kund and flowing through Devghat, holds a religious importance."

Swami Gyanananda Saraswoti said that one's wishes would come true by taking a bath in Devghat on the Maghe Sankranti (the first day of Magh Month according to lunar calendar). Religious scriptures mention that one attains salvation by bathing here during Maghe Sankranti, he added.

Every year, thousands of local and international devotees come to Devghat to take a holy dip on the day of Maghe Sankranti. There is a religious belief that gods and goddesses come to bathe in Devghat on the occasion.

Meanwhile, the Devghat Development Committee has been organising the Maghe Sankranti fair every year. It has made arrangements for devotees in Aanpatari, Ramnagar, Thimura and Dasdhunga. Starting this year, the devotees can also take the route from Keladi in Gaidakot to reach Devghat.

Similarly, personnel from Nepal Police, Armed Police Force and traffic policemen from Chitwan, Tanahun and Nawalparasi districts have been deployed to maintain peace and provide transportation service.



PHOTO: BASANTA PARAJULI /TRN
A bamboo being erected to signal the beginning of Makar Sankranti in Devghat Dham on Sunday.

72% of residents in Dhankuta out of health insurance coverage

BY KABIRAJ GHIMIRE
Hile, Jan. 14

The current enrolment in health insurance stands at 42,189 individuals, constituting 28 per cent of the total population of 149,984, in Dhankuta district, according to the 2078 census. Despite this progress, 72 per cent of Dhankuta's residents are still out of health insurance coverage.

To participate in the health insurance programme, families of up to five members are required to pay an annual fee of 3,500 rupees.

An additional provision exists for families with more than five members, necessitating an extra payment of Rs. 700 per member.

The government, under Health Insurance Regulations 2075, extends free health insurance to senior citizens aged 70 and above.

This initiative encompasses health services worth Rs. 100,000 annually for five members included with the insurance scheme.

Challenges persist, with some citizens facing barriers to joining health insurance due to the lack of information and financial constraints. Tanka Bahadur Rai, a resident, emphasised that despite the programme's significance, inadequate awareness and financial constraints hinder people's participation.

The health insurance programme has been in operation since the fiscal year 2015/16, aiming to provide accessible health services after establishing basic healthcare as a fundamental right for Nepalese citizens under Article 35 of the Constitution of Nepal 2015.

> To participate in the health insurance programme, families of up to five members are required to pay an annual fee of 3,500 rupees.

Namita Khatiwada, the coordinator of Health Insurance Board Dhankuta, confirmed the programme's continuity since 2020 in Dhankuta.

In Dhankuta, health insurance beneficiaries can access facilities at various primary health centers and district hospitals. Dhankuta Hospital witnesses 100 to 150 insured individuals seeking treatment daily.

However, challenges arise when the government delays providing the required funding, affecting the timely procurement of medicines, as highlighted by Amitabh Thakur, Acting Head of Dhankuta Hospital.

Recognising the ongoing challenges, local initiatives have emerged to boost health insurance coverage.

Chhathar Jorpati Rural Municipality is contributing 50 per cent of the health insurance amount for all citizens, while Sangurigarhi Rural Municipality is covering the health insurance premium for Dalit community members and women health volunteers.

Efforts continue to bridge the gap in health insurance coverage, addressing awareness, financial constraints, and operational issues in Dhankuta.

NEWS BRIEF

Five held with eight kg hashish

Makwanpur: Police arrested five persons with about 8 kg and 800 grams of charas, the finest form of hashish, on Saturday night.

Among those arrested are 40-year-old Ram Narayan Shrestha of Naya Basti, Manahari Rural Municipality-6, 21-year-old Yakub Khan of Bara Jitpur Simra Sub-Metropolitan City-6, 20-year-old Mukesh Ram of Bara Parwanipur Rural Municipality-3, 20-year-old Irman Alam of Birgunj Sub-Metropolitan City-21, Parsa, and 21-year-old Soyal Minya.

The police deployed from the Area Police Office, Manahari, arrested Yakub Khan, who was coming from Chitwan towards Hetauda in a car with registration Na 3 Cha7404, in Manahari Rural Municipality-7, with 300 grams of Chares.

Two die in Jhapa road accident

Jhapa: Two persons were killed in separate road accidents in Jhapa district on Saturday.

In the accidents in Shivasatakshi Municipality-10 and Kamal Rural Municipality-3, eight others have sustained injuries.

Motorbike rider Anup Dhakal, 23, of Damak-9, lost his life when a car (Ba 14 Cha 6603) travelling from west to east collided with his motorbike (Me 10 Pa 7212) in Shivasatakshi-10.

DSP Khagendra Prasad Rijal of Jhapa Police said that Dhakal succumbed to his injuries during treatment at Birta City Hospital Birtamod. Pillion rider Pradeep Basnet, 21, of Urlabari-1, Morang, sustained injuries.

In the same incident, car driver Anil Kumar Sah, 50, of Birtamod-3, Jaya Prakash Sah, 53, of Birtamod-4, Ranjan Sah, 44, and Lalit Sah, 53, of Birtamod-3 sustained injuries.

In another road mishap, Raghunath Bhattarai, 70, of Kankai-3 died.

(TRN)

Grasslands management to reduce human-animal conflict



PHOTO: BOMLAL GIRI/TRN
Grazing land for rhinos is being prepared by felling trees.

BY BOM LAL GIRI
Nawalpur, Jan. 14

After the incidents of human-animal conflict increased in Nawalpur district, the need for grassland management was felt to deter wild animals from attacking the Nawalpur locals.

Grasslands have been established by clearing forests in Shantikunj, Kumarabarti, Samna and Krishnasar Community forests in the buffer zone areas of the Chitwan National Park (CNP) to provide rhinos with enough space.

Basu Dev Paudel, chairman of the Lamichour Buffer Zone Consumer's Committee, shared that 500 hectares of forests have been cleared, and 200 hectares have been transformed into wetlands in the Lamichour Buffer Zone Community Forest in Kawasoti-10, Nawalpur.

Additionally, other community forest groups have also given priority to grassland management.

The lack of grassland for wild animals persisted in the buffer zone community forest. To address this, a plan for grassland management has been developed to attract animals back into the forest.

Dhaniram Mahato from Kawasoti-7 said," We used to fetch firewood and fodder from the forest, and instances of human-animal conflict were not heard much, but now wild animals frequently enter the settlement and end up damaging the crops."

Narayan Prasad Timilsina, the former ward chairman of Kawasoti-10, expressed that the encroachment of the forest has intensified human-animal conflict. The wild beasts that were once content within the forest, started venturing into the settlements.

Timilsina said, "In recent years, wild animals have caused more trouble by entering villages compared to previous years.

He added, "Previously, there was ample grassland. However, with the protection of community forests, dense forests developed, and animals could not find sufficient grassland for grazing."

Ward No. 10 of the municipality has supported Rs. 200,000 to build a grassland. Other community groups have also been providing some financial support every year.

According to CNP officials, it is essential to have grasslands with suitable grass for rhinos, ponds for spotted deer, and other features for various animals. When these elements are provided within the forest, even tigers are less likely to enter settlements as they can find their prey in their natural habitat.

According to Nawalpur police, two individuals have lost their lives, and eight others have sustained injuries in tiger and rhino attacks in the district since May 2023. Two goats were killed in a recent tiger attack while six goats sustained injuries.

'Bhakka Day' marked in Jhapa

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHREL
Damak, Jan. 14

Locals in Jhapa celebrated 'Bhakka Day' on Sunday with a common commitment to promoting indigenous food. People belonging to the Koch Rajbanshi community living in Eastern Nepal have been celebrating Poush 29 (January 14 this year) as 'Bhakka Day' for the past seven years.

On the occasion, the Rajbanshi Society Development Committee organised various cultural programmes and distributed free bhakka at Domlal Rajbanshi Stadium in Birtamod.

Inaugurating the programme, Koshi Province Minister for Tourism, Forest and Environment Ganesh Prasad Upreti said that the day had been successful in promoting the original food of the Rajbanshi community. He said that the food should be carried as the brand of the region.

He said that Bhakka could be considered as an aspect of preserving traditional food and culture. "Our culture and food will help in promoting tourism. We are always ready to protect all cultures, languages and identities in the society." he said, "Bhakka once a traditional snack has evolved into a source of income for many women."

Bhakka is made by steaming rice flour in a small cake-like structure. It is often eaten during breakfast throughout the Tarai districts of the east. For many, Bhakka is a good breakfast with tea, especially during the winter.

"Bhakka Day, celebrated for the promotion and preservation of Bhakka which was at the state of being extinct from the Rajbanshi community, has been successful this year also," said Abhay Rajbanshi, chairman of Rajbanshi Community

He said more than 150 women prepared Bhakka using 2,000 kg of rice flour and distributed it free of cost on the occasion.



PHOTO: BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL/TRN
Participants in Bhakka Festival in Jhapa.

JUDGE'S WIFE ATTEMPTS SELF-IMMOLATION IN FRONT OF APEX COURT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

District judge Bhuwan Giri's wife Arati attempted self-immolation in front of the Supreme Court premises on Sunday.

Superintendent of Police for the Kathmandu District Police Range Kumud Dhungel said that she reached the Supreme Court and tried to commit self-immolation there.

The police said that she attempted self-immolation by hurling petrol on her body. She was about to pour petrol on her body when the police stopped her.

The police said that they seized a bottle of petrol and the matchbox from her. She had filed a case of marital rape against Judge Giri. Giri, who was arrested earlier, was released on bail by the court.

R.NO. 074-079-03617, case no. 079-cp-1767 case: divorse secter-4
Issued by Banke District court
A summon Notice with 21 days deadline issued in the name of Ravia wano Quresi daughter of Mr. Fida Hussain quresi, a resident of Mohalla Katra post Gosaigaumganj ward No. 12 Faizabad Tehsil Mother, India Uttar Pradesh ... .
The Summon notice issued by in this court in name of you defendant Ravia Wano Quresi in the divorce case filed in this court on 2023/4/17 A.D. by and between the plaintiff salim Quresi and the defendant Ravia wano quresi, was seeved at no address twice on date 2023/10/16 AD has between returned without being Served. therefore, the Summon notice in your name has been published in Rising Nepal daily Newspaper. From the date of publication of this Summon notice, within 21 days excluding the time taken for Journey enroute, do appear before this Court in Person, or through your attorney or your legal representative with evidence you have, if you live Lapsing the deadlines without appearing to the court the case will be trialed in accordance to the law, later your claim will not be accepted.
Done on 15th January 2024 A.D on Monday.

Chitwan reports four scrub typhus deaths with 163 infections

RSS
Narayangadh (Chitwan), Jan 14

Chitwan reports four deaths from scrub typhus in the current fiscal and of them, one is from the district and remaining three from outside the district, according to the Health Office, Chitwan.

As said by office vector control inspector, Ram KC, so far in the current fiscal year, there are 163 confirmed cases of scrub out of 3,254 tests and among the infected, four succumbed to the disease that is caused by bacteria called Orientia tsutsugamushi.

Among the infected, 88 are from Chitwan and the remaining from other districts.

Last fiscal year, 519 scrub typhus infected were identified among tests conducted on 3485 who visited the district-based hospitals for treatment.

All the infected recovered following the treatment.

> Among the infected, 88 are from Chitwan and the remaining from other districts.

Scrub typhus bacteria do not directly transmit to human, but infects mites found in vegetation and the infected mites.

Severe fever, reddish eyes, coughing, vomiting, stomach pain, loose bowels, breathing difficulties, joint and muscle pain, skin rashes and sometimes the appearance of black posts at the site of the bite are among the symptoms of scrub typhus.

Similarly, the number of reported dengue cases in the district since July 17 is 1,615 following the 21,298 tests. One death has been reported from the disease and the death was outside from Chitwan.

Notice for Intent to award the contract
(Date of Publication : 15 January, 2024)
Pursuant to sub clause 27.2 and 27.3 of Public Procurement Act 2063, this is to notify all concerned bidders that it is our intention to award the contract to the following bidder for the Tender Notice No. KSCL/D/ICB-158/080/081 for Supply and Delivery of 25,000±2% MT of DAP as per the Invitation for Bids published on 7 November, 2023 in 'The Rising Nepal' & www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp as it is found substantially responsive and lowest evaluated bidder.

Tender Notice No.	Name of the successful bidder	Bidder rate in USD/MT	Total Amount
KSCL/D/ICB-158/080/081	M/S Indian Potash Limited, New Delhi, India	CIP Birgunj - CIP Biratnagar - CIP Bhairahawa- 729.00	USD 1,82,25,000.00

KRISHI SAMAGRI COMPANY LTD.
Procurement Department, Head Office
Kathmandu, Nepal.
Tel : (+9771) 5374819
E-mail: aicl.nepal@gmail.com

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

All men's miseries derive from not being able to sit in a quiet room alone.
- Blaise Pascal

EDITORIAL

Refine Weather Forecast

Scientists have not yet been successful in predicting earthquake but they are now able to forecast other natural events such as the temperature, rainfall, snowfall, heatwaves, coldwaves, and cyclones. As the climate patterns are increasingly becoming erratic, an accurate weather forecast is crucial in everyday life of people. A correct weather warning saves the lives and property from natural disasters such as heavy downpours, landslides, floods and hurricanes. Not only this, the precise weather forecasts boost the sports, tourism, agriculture and trade, too. Big sporting events are well-organised according to the weather forecasts. Tourists choose to visit their desired destinations as per the forecasts on temperature and precipitation. Accurate forecasts help farmers decide on plantation and production of the given crops. Besides, business companies estimate demand and arrange supplies of goods on the basis of weather forecasts.

This is why weather forecasting has been an important business of government. Investment in it brings many benefits to a country. It is entirely a technical issue, requiring advanced technology, knowledge and human inputs. Meteorologists collect quantitative data about the current state of the atmosphere, land, and ocean, and forecast the weather change in particular places. Being a mountainous country with diverse tropical features, Nepal endures severe impacts of climate change, posing a challenge for accurate long-range weather predictions. Experts also point out to dearth of data for calibration observation. The Department of Hydrology and Meteorology has made seasonal outlook by integrating regional and global models but DHM's forecasts have shown higher discrepancies compared to other countries.

According to news report of this daily, DHM has predicted above-normal rainfall for this winter (December to February) but the country has not witnessed rainfall as more than one and half a months went by so far. It has forecast a 55 to 65 per cent chance of above-average rainfall in the northeast parts of Sudurpaschim Province and the northern parts of Karnali Province. Likewise, a 45 to 55 per cent chance of above-average rainfall is expected in the eastern and southern parts of Sudurpaschim Province, southern parts of Karnali Province, all parts of Lumbini Province except the eastern parts, Gandaki Province, northwest parts of Bagmati Province, and northeast parts of Koshi Province. Similarly, it has predicted a 35 to 45 per cent chance of below-average rainfall in the southern parts of Koshi Province and the central and eastern parts of Madhes Province during the period.

As only three to four per cent of the total annual rainfall takes place in the winter, the DHM hopes that its prediction will come true with three to four precipitation events even in late February. Some experts insist that there should be at least two rainfall events in December and four in January to achieve normal rainfall. For above-normal rainfall, there should be heavy precipitations in a single or two days in the remaining period. On the other hand, the global model shows the South Asian countries, including Nepal, will remain dry this winter. The DHM started seasonal outlook in 2020 but it is still unable to divide the forecast into separate months in the absence of technology, trained human resources and knowledge. This is a reason why its forecast may not be 100 per cent accurate. It is imperative to equip the DHM with necessary resources to improve its seasonal outlook.

Perils Of AI

BRITTI ARYAL

While talking about the rapid pace of technological development, a digital revolution in Artificial Intelligence (AI) has caught the attention of many. The computer-based algorithms that complete tasks and solve problems without the requirement of human intelligence and time have gained popularity among all. With the power to make vast improvements to our quality of life, AI has been a perfect tool. By enhancing the accuracy and efficiency of decision-making and simplifying the lives of people, AI has been gaining massive users throughout the world.

Looking from various perspectives, AI has shown its potential in many fields. From enhancing affordable healthcare to immense development in the educational sector and from developing high-tech solutions to graphical evolutions, AI has moved technology one step forward. AI has shown its endless possibilities in almost every sector. The changes AI has brought are astounding. A computer-based programme with the ability to think and learn on its own has made our lives better and easier.

With consistency and perfection in every task it performs, it has left humans behind. Not only can an AI programme run constantly, but it can also do the same task with the same standard forever. It never gets tired. A properly trained machine learning algorithm that can analyse massive data in a limited time has supplemented human's ability to perform. Fewer errors and fewer downtime features have been a great factor in the rise of AI.

But AI is not without drawbacks. Its rapid and all-encompassing involvement poses a huge risk to humanity, so it is critical to note the cons of this powerful technology. AI has been a dangerous tool with no ability to control itself. Lately, AI-generated images and videos and AI-powered voice changers have been widely used. Creating realistic photos/videos or audio clips and replacing the image of one figure with another has created a lot of confusion and conflicts. It is difficult to know what is real and what is fake.

Social manipulations through AI algorithms have been more problematic. Data privacy has been a major concern too. An overreliance on AI technology has curtailed human creativity at the same time. As AI-powered job automation goes in demand, it threatens to displace human resources. With capital-exhaustive technologies, human-intensive requirements have decreased in some industries. Humans are being replaced with machines. Implementation of AI-like robots has already displaced many occupations, leading to severe unemployment. AI algorithms have become more sophisticated in creating ethical dilemmas.

The pace of economic changes AI has brought is spectacular. It has enhanced the quality of life by forcing us to shift conditions more quickly. However, machines are not rational and can only do what they are taught, and people are misusing it by giving negative and unwanted commands. A machine-based algorithm trying to replicate the commands and abilities of the human brain is worrying. Many forms of misalignment and harm exist in AI which need to be addressed. Stating its harm doesn't mean we should stop using AI but everyone needs to understand its limitations to implement it in the right way. People need to understand the range of potential harms that AI systems pose and must know the ways to mitigate them.

In B'desh, Beyond Poll Victory



P Kharel

TIDE OF TIMES

Far too predictably, Awami League leader Hasina Wajed has led her Awami League to the fourth consecutive win in the violence-marred January 7 parliamentary elections that were boycotted by Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP), the key opposition. The boycott call contributed to the low voter turnout of a disputed 41 per cent as against 80 per cent turnout in 2018. The Awami League obtained three-fourths of the total parliament seats and most of the remaining winners were "independent" candidates known to be from the ruling party. Hasina fielded scores of her party members as independent candidates to avoid an embarrassment of an opposition-free parliament.

After the political change in December 1990, voters in Bangladesh have not been deprived of casting their ballot papers. Nor have they experienced any military takeover since then. Bangladesh presents a story of periodic elections and steady economic growth rates. However, elections can churn out autocratic rule if discrepancies in the governance of a state go unaccounted for. Interrelated as they are, both the components are essential in a functioning democracy.

Hence, Bangladesh's engagement in democratic practices should compare with the experiences and expectations of other multiparty systems. It does compare well with not only its South Asian neighbours but many others among developing economies. If it used to be cited as a nation of teeming multi-millions most of whom were in a state of semi-starvation and malnutrition five decades ago, the table now has turned for a dramatic better and is looked at with envy by many other nations struggling for meeting their basic needs.

Remarkable stride

In the world's most-populous region of South Asia that accounts for every fifth person on Earth, Bangladesh's story is remarkable. Frequent lockdowns and boycott of parliament marked the first decade and a half since the 1990 changes. A running fierce feud between the Awami League and the BNP adversely impacted the growth rate. By the 2010s, the economy began to register an upward swing. New policies have placed the world's "basket case"—as Henry Kissinger once in the 1970s disparagingly tagged the nation—to conditions that have drawn appreciation from both the neighbourhood and beyond.

At 7.2 per cent GDP growth a year ago, the country achieved one of the fastest records in the world, which was higher than those of India, Indonesia and the Philippines, among Asian nations. It now paces toward emerging as an upper-middle income country.

China had been assessing Bangladesh's economic pace to visitors from the neighbourhood, including Nepal. It is to this scribe's knowledge that at least three professors from different universities in China had told foreign guests that Bangladesh was an emerging economy whose transformation would be acknowledged well within the 2020s. Under Hasina's stewardship, Dhaka has begun looking beyond the immediate region for new opportunities with long-term prospects. Its hopes of becoming a fast-developing economy by the next decade is not an improbable target, with also the potential of emerging as a credible regional power.

Bangladesh's garment industry ranks as the world's second largest, which makes for 11 per cent of GDP and contributes to 80 per cent of the country's export revenue. Governments in the past three decades

> A functioning democracy, based on rule of law, transparency and accountability, steers a government on a responsible path that should improve the living standards and meet the realistic aspirations of a maximum of people.

appreciably responded to demands for changes in law and regulations and with free-market approach. One of the poorest regions of British India, its conditions remained unchanged for decades even after it broke away from Pakistan to become an independent Bangladesh in 1971. Political assassinations and military-backed rule marked much of the next 15 years. Mass uprising in 1990 brought down the HM Ershad regime and paved way for democratic reforms.

In 1994, during Prime Minister Khaleda Zia's fourth year in office, the League resorted to frequent boycott of parliament to press for an independent caretaker government for conducting elections. Although the demand was eventually met after a series of incidents, the League backtracked on its stand when it came to power and changed the rule in a reverse of its earlier stand.

Disturbing

Undoubtedly, Bangladesh has come a long way since the early 1990s. But democratic aspirations of the general people, particularly those of the youth, should be addressed through timely responses and reforms. Several thousand activists of BNP were reported to have been arrested on the eve of the 2018 elections. Charges that critics, including journalists, are regularly put behind bars are of serious nature and implications. At the same time, BNP's boycott of last week's election cannot be taken lightly. It dismisses the exercise as a "disgrace" while Hasina Wajed considers BNP a "terrorist" organisation.

Fear of Islamic radicalism emanates primarily since the religious extremist violence in 2016, when 24 people were killed in a blast in Dhaka. The Awami League government cracked down on some extremist groups but is seen to have cultivated rapport with other anti-secularist groups in a country where Muslims constitute 90 per cent of the 173 million people. Economic success alone cannot guarantee democratic governance, as numerous instances in various parts of the world have shown time and again. Commitment to democracy in practice would serve the Awami League government well.

Flushed with her fourth consecutive electoral victory, Hasina Wajed cannot afford complacency over the principal opposition's non-participation in the latest general election. BNP and former Prime Minister Khaleda Zia, now under house arrest after court conviction in corruption cases, will not lie low. They await a chance to strike in a manner their strength can best muster. The ruling side's best defence would be in greater democratic practices and higher living standards for an average Bangladeshi.

A functioning democracy, based on rule of law, transparency and accountability, steers a government on a responsible path that should improve the living standards and meet the realistic aspirations of a maximum of people. Already the longest ruling prime minister in South Asia, Hasina Wajed's fourth consecutive term following a previous one term needs to engage in actions that enhance her democratic credentials and accelerate the economic pace.

(Professor Kharel specialises in political communication.)

Regulate The Errant Cooperatives



Ballav Dahal

Until few years in the past, political leaders, government officials and cooperative campaigners used to deliver lengthy speeches, highlighting cooperatives as an important means of socio-economic development in Nepal. The Constitution of Nepal, 2015 recognises cooperatives as one of the three pillars for the development of national economy, with the remaining two being public and private sectors. In line with this constitutional recognition, the government has embraced the policy of promoting cooperatives to advance the process of economic development. But many cooperatives have now been going through obstacles. The common people, as depositors, are forced to bear the brunt of this problem as they are unable to get their deposits back. In the aftermath of COVID-19, a lot of depositors associated with numerous cooperatives across the country have failed to return their money.

In dearth of effective regulation and monitoring, hundreds of cooperatives nationwide are believed to have turned bankrupt while many others have remained closed. Cooperative operators are mostly responsible for such a worsening scenario. Cooperatives were able to collect a lot of money by offering high interest rates on deposits and other benefits to depositors. But many cooperative operators have disappeared from the scene after abusing deposits, forcing depositors to stage street protests. Although the government has tried to return the money to depositors from cooperatives, it has not been successful in doing so. And those who had deposited their hard-earned money in cooperatives have now been left in the lurch. They are unsure when the cooperatives they are affiliated with will give their money back to them.

Depositors' plight

The authorities, including the Department of Cooperatives, are also to blame for the plight of depositors because the former did not take the required steps to safeguard the deposits of citizens. Had they stepped up necessary measures on time, the problem would not have exacerbated. However, the government has reiterated its commitment to bringing the fraudsters to justice. But what is astonishing is that neither the government authorities nor cooperatives have actual information about the actual amounts of money deposited by citizens, unsettled payment dues and loans disbursed for investment. At least 10 cooperatives within the Kathmandu Valley alone are accused of abusing as much as Rs. 35 billion deposited by people. More than 500 cooperatives across the nation are now suspected to have been problematic. However, the government has declared only 15 cooperatives as troubled ones.

At present, the number of cooperatives in the country stands at about 34,000. Of them, 14,000 are saving and credit cooperatives. Mostly, saving and credit cooperatives are in trouble. There is no doubt that many cooperatives have been grappling with problems because they have not followed even basic principles and values of cooperatives. Most cooperatives are found to have been established and run by family members and other relatives. Those having nexus with political parties, leaders and other power centres have also been linked to cooperatives. Such persons are found to have been involved in the misappropriation of depositors' money as they are guided by ill-intentions. It has become easier for such groups to swindle people of their money as anyone could establish cooperatives anywhere they liked. Cashing in on the legal loopholes, cooperative operators expanded

> The Cooperatives Act has a mandatory provision for cooperatives to return deposits to the concerned depositors within three months of the latter's demand. The government must implement this provision.

their working areas with the sole intent of cheating more people.

Instead of being just a mute spectator, the authorities must take stringent measures to take cooperatives back on track. They must leave no stone unturned when it comes to protecting depositors' money. The authorities have lost their public trust because of their apathy towards such a serious problem. The Department of Cooperatives should have carried out its responsibility of monitoring cooperatives properly as mandated by the existing laws, including the Cooperatives Act, 2017. However, cooperative experts say that there are many loopholes in the Cooperatives Act itself. The lawmakers should have held a series of deliberations and discussions before getting the bill endorsed from the federal parliament. Their carelessness has cost high for the common depositors. The government and the responsible political parties must take this matter seriously and initiate the process of amending the Act so as to address the legal gaps.

As the government body -- Department of Cooperatives -- allows individuals to establish cooperatives, it is its responsibility to safeguard the depositors' money. The Cooperatives Act has a mandatory provision for cooperatives to return deposits to the concerned depositors within three months of the latter's demand. The government must implement this provision.

It is worth recalling here that about 10 years ago, a high-level commission headed by former judge Gauri Bahadur Karki submitted its comprehensive report to the then government in regard to regulating cooperatives effectively. The report also included suggestions aimed at dealing with varied problems facing the cooperative sector. The commission also pointed out various risks associated with protection of deposits. But the authorities were not very considerate about the issue. If those suggestions had been followed, the ongoing crisis facing cooperatives would have been prevented, to a great extent. However, learning from numerous incidences of cheating in the name of cooperatives, the government has now stopped the registration of new cooperatives.

Wrong practice

As the real estate business was thriving, a lot of cooperatives invested much in this sector. But like other sectors, the real estate business, too, started facing problems after the COVID-19 pandemic. Thus, a large chunk of depositors' money has been stuck in this unproductive sector. This is a wrong practice. Even the cooperatives that are currently running smoothly are likely to face the same fate as others if necessary interventions are not made immediately. As per the Cooperatives Act, police personnel cannot file any case against cooperative operators, depositors and debtors. The police can move ahead only when the local government, concerned bodies and other agencies file cases at the police office. With this clumsy process, there are chances for wrongdoers to evade any arrest. This type of state of impunity seems to have encouraged even others to follow suit. The government must take up this matter gravely and act accordingly so as to bring cooperatives on track.

(The author is a former deputy executive editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 15, 1974

Bangla Airlines Plane Arriving On Test Flight

Kathmandu, Jan.14: A Fokker-27 aircraft of Bangla Airlines is arriving at Tribhuvan airport tomorrow on a test flight, says RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Boost Domestic Manufacturing

Your news report titled *"New Nepal-made tractors hit market"* published on Jan. 14 was a delight to read. Chandragiri machinery Udhyog has begun the production and distribution of Chandragiri Tractors with the capacity of 6HP (Horse Power) and 9HP. What I found the most appealing features of these machines are they are priced at Rs. 175,000 and Rs. 200,000, prices that are within the reach of the farmers, vast majority of whom are poor. With their launching, a hope that they will bring more people into the agriculture sector has risen.

Besides, it has shown that we can manufacture machines we need to enhance our productivity. And without steep growth in manufacturing, we cannot go far in our development endeavour.



Manufacturing domestically also spares us from having to import costly machineries – the process which drains our foreign exchange reserves.

Treading in that direction, if we go on manufacturing many other essential equipment, our effort towards prosperity will surely get a much-needed boost.

Nikeesa Neupane
Kathamandu

TAILPIECE

A group of four-year-olds were being questioned by their teacher in a Sunday School class. Looking across at those bright little faces, the teacher asked this question: "Does anyone know what today is?" A little girl held up her hand and said, "Yes, today is Palm Sunday."

"That's fantastic!" the teacher said. "Now does anyone know what next Sunday is?" The same little girl lifted her hand. "Yes," she said, "next Sunday is Easter Sunday." The teacher was all smiles. "Oh, very good. Now...does anyone know what makes next Sunday Easter?"

On a roll the same little girl responded, "Yes, next Sunday is Easter because Jesus rose from the grave." Before the impressed teacher could congratulate her, however, the girl added, "but if He sees His shadow, He has to go back in for seven weeks."

NKorea launches missile that can reach distant US bases

AP
Seoul, South Korea, Jan. 14

North Korea fired a suspected intermediate-range ballistic missile into the sea on Sunday, South Korea's military said, two months after the North claimed to have tested engines for a new harder-to-detect missile capable of striking distant U.S. targets in the region.

The launch was the North's first this year. Experts say North Korea could ramp up its provocative missile tests as a way to influence the results of South Korea's parliamentary elections in April and the U.S. presidential election in November.

South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff said in a statement that it detected the launch of a ballistic missile of an intermediate-range class from the North's capital region on Sunday afternoon. It said the missile flew about 1,000 kilometres (620 miles) before landing in the waters between the Korean Peninsula and Japan.

The Joint Chiefs of Staff called the launch a provocation that poses a serious threat to peace on the Korean Peninsula. It said South Korea's military will maintain its readiness to overwhelmingly respond to any provocations by North Korea.

The South Korean assessment suggests North Korea could have launched a new intermediate-range ballistic missile, whose solid-fuel engine it said it had tested in mid-November.

The missile is mainly designed to hit U.S. military bases in the U.S. Pacific territory of Guam, which is about 3,400 kilometres (2,110 miles) from Pyongyang, the North's capital. With a range adjustment, the missile can also be used to attack closer targets — the U.S. military installations in Japan's Okinawa island, according to Chang Young-keun, a missile expert at the Korea Research Institute for National Strategy in Seoul.

Japan's Defense Ministry said its analysis showed the missile travelled at least 500 kilometres (300 miles) at the maximum altitude of 50 kilometres (30 miles), data that suggest North Korea may have fired a short-range and not an intermediate-range missile.

Japan and South Korea said they closely exchanged information about the launch with the United States, but they didn't immediately explain the discrepancy in data.

The last time North Korea performed a missile launch that was publicly announced was Dec. 18, when it test-fired its Hwasong-18 solid-fuelled intercontinental ballistic missile, the North's most advanced weapon. The Hwasong-18 is the country's only known solid-fuel ICBM and it's designed to strike the mainland U.S.

On Jan. 5, North Korea fired a barrage of artillery shells near the disputed western sea boundary with South Korea, prompting South Korea to conduct similar firing exercises in the same area. South Korea accused North Korea of continuing similar artillery barrage in the area for the next two days. The site is where the navies of the two Koreas have fought three bloody sea battles since 1999, and attacks blamed on North Korea killed 50 South Koreans in 2010.



PHOTO: AP

A TV screen shows a file image of North Korea's missile launch during a news programme at the Seoul Railway Station in Seoul, South Korea, Sunday, Jan. 14, 2024.

In recent days, North Korea has also been escalating its warlike, inflammatory rhetoric against its foes ahead of an election year in South Korea and the U.S. Leader Kim Jong Un, during visits last week to munitions factories, called South Korea "our principal enemy" and threatened to annihilate it if provoked.

Experts say Kim likely wants to see South Korean liberals win the election and pursue rapprochement with North Korea, and for former U.S. President Donald Trump to be elected again. They say Kim may believe he could win U.S. concessions like sanctions relief if Trump returns to the White House.

Negotiations over North Korea's advancing nuclear arsenal have been dormant since the Kim-Trump diplomacy broke down in 2019. Kim has since focused on enlarging his nuclear and missile arsenals in what foreign analysts is an effort to boost his leverage. In recent months, North Korea has also been expanding its military and other cooperation with Russia.

The U.S. government said it has evidence that missiles provided by North Korea to Russia had been used in the war in Ukraine. In a joint statement last week, the U.S., South Korea and their partners said the missile transfer supports Russia's war of aggression and provides North Korea with valuable technical and military insights.

North Korea and Russia announced Sunday that North Korean Foreign Minister Choe Son Hui will visit Russia from Monday to Wednesday at the invitation of her Russian counterpart Sergey Lavrov.

FIVE MIGRANTS DIE AFTER TRYING TO REACH BRITAIN

AFP
Dunkirk, northern France, Jan. 14

Four migrants died overnight and a fifth was found dead on Sunday after trying to reach Britain from northern France despite freezing temperatures, the French maritime authority said.

The group was attempting to reach a vessel off Wimereux when their small boat got into difficulty around 2am (01:00 GMT), the maritime prefecture told AFP.

"We have four dead migrants and one migrant in a critical condition at the hospital in Boulogne-sur-mer," said one official.

A fifth migrant was found dead late Sunday morning, the maritime prefecture said.

A tugboat patrolling the coast went to the rescue and found the bodies, the first reported migrant deaths on the Channel in 2024.

The region around Calais, the jumping-off point for the shortest crossing to England, has long been a magnet for migrants.

More than two decades after the closure of a Red Cross centre in Sangatte, hundreds of people still live in tents and makeshift shelters near Calais and Dunkirk, hoping for a chance to make the crossing hidden in a truck or aboard a small boat.

The boats are a political priority for the British government and a bone of contention with France, as tens of thousands of people a year have been making the dangerous crossing.

According to the British government nearly 30,000 migrants crossed the Channel from mainland Europe to Britain in small boats in 2023, an annual drop of more than a third.

Japan's PM vows more funds to quake-hit zone



PHOTO: AP

Japan's Prime Minister Fumio Kishida visiting the country's north-central region of Noto for the first time since the Jan. 1 quakes.

AP
Tokyo, Jan. 14

Japan's Prime Minister Fumio Kishida said he was "speechless" by the severity and immense destruction of the disaster zone he saw during the helicopter ride on his first visit to the country's north-central region of Noto since the deadly Jan. 1 earthquakes, amid worries about spreading diseases in evacuation centres.

Kishida pledged to do his utmost to improve the living conditions of the evacuees and to rebuild their homes and restore their livelihoods as soon as possible.

The magnitude 7.6 earthquake left 221 dead and more than 20 others still missing while injuring hundreds. More than 20,000 people, many of whom had their homes damaged or destroyed, are taking refuge at about 400 school gymnasiums, community centres and other makeshift facilities, according to the Fire and Disaster Management Agency report.

Road damage has hampered rescue efforts, and though relief supplies have reached most regions affected by the quake, hundreds of people in isolated areas are getting little support. Additionally, in the hard-hit towns of Noto, Wajima and Suzu, elderly residents account for half their population, and many are facing growing risks of deteriorating health, officials and experts say.

The prime minister said he took the evacuee's conditions seriously and promised support. "We will do everything we can so that you can have hope for the future," he said.

Kishida also met with Ishikawa Gov. Hiroshi Hase in the prefectural government in Kanazawa, where he was given a list of requests, including central government funding for the reconstruction of key infrastructure, and emergency loans for individuals and small businesses.

No one can halt war to crush Hamas: Netanyahu

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Jan. 14

Israel will pursue its war against Hamas until victory and will not be stopped by anyone, including the world court, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said in a defiant speech Saturday, as the fighting in Gaza approached the 100-day mark.

Netanyahu spoke after the International Court of Justice at The Hague held two days of hearings on South Africa's allegations that Israel is committing genocide against Palestinians, a charge Israel has rejected as libellous and hypocritical. South Africa asked the court to order Israel to halt its blistering air and ground offensive in an interim step.

"No one will stop us, not The Hague, not the axis of evil and not anyone else," Netanyahu said in televised remarks Saturday evening, referring to Iran and its allied militias.

The case before the world court is expected to go on for years, but a ruling on interim steps could come within weeks. Court rulings are binding but difficult to enforce. Netanyahu made clear that Israel would ignore orders to halt the fighting, potentially deepening its isolation.

Israel has been under growing international pressure to end the war, which has killed more than 23,000 Palestinians in Gaza and led to widespread suffering in the besieged enclave, but has so far been shielded by U.S. diplomatic and military support.

Thousands took to the streets of Washington, London, Paris, Rome, Milan and Dublin on Saturday to demand an end to the war. Protesters converging on the White House held aloft signs questioning President Joe Biden's viability as a presidential candidate because of his staunch support for Israel during the war.

Israel argues that ending the war means victory for Hamas, the Islamic militant group that has ruled Gaza since 2007 and is bent on Israel's destruction.



PHOTO: AP

Judges start a hearing at the International Court of Justice in The Hague, Netherlands, Friday, Jan. 12, 2024. The United Nations' top court opened hearings Thursday into South Africa's allegation that Israel's war with Hamas amounts to genocide against Palestinians, a claim that Israel strongly denies.

The war was triggered by a deadly Oct. 7 attack in which Hamas and other militants killed some 1,200 people in Israel, mostly civilians. About 250 more were taken hostage, and while some have been released or confirmed dead, more than half are believed to still be in captivity. Sunday marks 100 days of fighting.

Fears of a wider conflagration have been palpable since the start of the war. New fronts quickly opened, with Iran-backed groups — Houthi rebels in Yemen, Hezbollah in Lebanon and Iran-backed militias in Iraq and Syria — carrying out a range of attacks. From the start, the U.S. increased its military presence in the region to deter an escalation.

Following a Houthi campaign of drone and missile attacks on commercial ships in the Red Sea, the U.S. and Britain launched multiple airstrikes against the rebels Friday, and the U.S. hit another site Saturday.

In more fallout from the war, the world court this week heard arguments on South Africa's complaint against Israel. South Africa cited the soaring death toll and hardships among Gaza civilians, along with inflammatory comments from Israeli leaders presented, as proof of what it called genocidal intent.

In counter arguments Friday, Israel asked for the case to be dismissed as meritless. Israel's defense argued that the country has the right to fight back against a ruthless enemy, that South Africa had barely mentioned Hamas, and that it ignored what Israel considers attempts to mitigate civilian harm.

Meanwhile, Netanyahu and his army chief, Herzl Halevi, said they have no immediate plans to allow the return of displaced Palestinians to northern Gaza, the initial focus of Israel's offensive. Fighting in the northern half has been scaled back, with forces now focusing on the southern city of Khan Younis, though combat continues in parts of the north.

PRISM

Man stops for coffee, wins $1million

North Carolina: A North Carolina man said a Sunday morning stop for coffee led to his winning a $1 million lottery prize.

William Roberts of Morrisville told North Carolina Education Lottery officials he went to the Circle K on Davis Drive in Morrisville for a caffeine fix and ended up buying a $10 Million Spectacular scratch-off lottery ticket for $50.

"I got up Sunday morning and went to buy a cup of coffee from the store," he said. "I sat in my car drinking my coffee while I scratched my ticket."

The ticket turned out to be a $1 million jackpot winner.

Roberts said he has been buying the tickets ever since his first one earned him a $500 prize. "I've been doing pretty well on that $50 ticket," he said. "This win was unbelievable though."

Roberts said he will invest his winnings back into his business.

"I'm a truck driver," he said, "so I'll probably invest the money into buying more trucks for my business."

Singing cockatiel found wandering in town

Bolton: Animal rescuers in Britain are trying to find the owner of a talkative parrot found wandering down a street.

The RSPCA said the male cockatiel was found to have an extensive vocabulary and an impressive repertoire of songs after being rescued near a bench in the Kearsley area of Bolton, England.

"He sings 'If you're happy and you know it' and waits for you to clap, as well as a few other songs and phrases," RSPCA animal rescue officer Helen Chapman said in a news release.

The RSPCA dubbed the bird Peek-a-boo and placed him with in a foster home.

"Peek-a-boo is extremely tame and is a delightful character who has been well looked after and loved by someone, who must have spent a lot of time on him," Chapman said.

(Agencies)

US climate envoy Kerry stepping down

AFP
Washington, Jan. 14

US climate envoy John Kerry, a key player in the Biden administration's push to tackle climate change, will step down to work on the president's re-election bid, media reported Saturday.

The former secretary of state and senator has spent the last three years liaising with other countries to up commitments on climate change, including at the most recent COP28 UN climate summit in Dubai.

Kerry, 80, intends to help Joe Biden's campaign by publicizing the president's work in combatting global warming, according to multiple US media outlets citing officials familiar with the situation.

Kerry informed Biden of his intentions to leave on Wednesday, and his staff learned of the decision on Saturday, those officials said.

Apart from leading the US delegation at three UN climate summits, Kerry worked effectively with China despite complicated diplomatic relations. Together, the countries are the world's two largest polluters, accounting for 41 percent of greenhouse gas emissions.

In a rare display of unity, the United States and China helped carry the COP28 December climate summit in Dubai, where negotiators sealed a historic although watered-down agreement to begin to transition away from oil, gas and coal.

Kerry had welcomed his Chinese counterpart Xie Zhenhua a month earlier in California, where the two countries agreed on outlines of climate action that partly served as a basis for the nearly 200-nation Dubai deal.

News of Kerry's stepping down comes one day after Xie retired on health grounds.



PHOTO: AP

US Special Presidential Climate Envoy John Kerry testifies before a House Oversight Subcommittee on National Security, the Border, and Foreign Affairs hearing on the State Department's climate budget on Capitol Hill in Washington, D.C. on July 13, 2023.

One of Biden's first moves in office after his inauguration on January 20, 2021 was to rejoin the Paris climate agreement, which former president Donald Trump had exited.

Under the 2015 UN deal countries committed to limiting the Earth's warming to "well below" 2 degrees Celsius and preferably to the safer 1.5C threshold.

That said, the year of 2023 was the hottest on record, with the increase in Earth's surface temperature nearly crossing the critical 1.5C threshold, according to EU climate monitors.

Kerry, himself a onetime Democratic presidential nominee, will step down sometime in the coming months, according to Axios, which first reported the news. The White House and Kerry's office did not immediately respond to a request for comment from AFP.

TODAY IN HISTORY

69 – Otho seizes power in Rome, proclaiming himself Emperor of Rome, beginning a reign of only three months.
1541 – King Francis I of France gives Jean-François Roberval a commission to settle the province of New France (Canada) and provide for the spread of the "Holy Catholic faith".
1559 – Elizabeth I is crowned Queen of England and Ireland in Westminster Abbey, London.
1759 – The British Museum opens to the public.
1777 – American Revolutionary War: New Connecticut (present-day Vermont) declares its independence.
1815 – War of 1812: American frigate USS President, commanded by Commodore Stephen Decatur, is captured by a squadron of four British frigates.
1892 – James Naismith publishes the rules of basketball.

CHINESE MEDIA TEAM VISITS GORKHAPATRA

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

A 10-member delegation of media representatives from China's Yunnan Province visited the Gorkhapatra Corporation on Sunday.

The delegation led by Peng Bin, Deputy Director-General of the Publicity Department of the Communist Party of China (CPC) Yunnan Provincial Committee, was welcomed by Executive Chairman of the Corporation Bishnu Prasad Subedi and its General Manager Lal Bahadur Airi.

On the occasion, Chairman Subedi said that Gorkhapatra was a historical institution representing Nepalis journalism. He said that the corporation made significant contributions to the nation's social and cultural development, documenting every political change and movement in Nepal.

He also praised China's continuous support in various development sectors.

Managing Director Airi said that Nepal-China shared strong relationship and Nepal could benefit from China's development efforts.

Shiva Kumar Bhattarai, Chief Editor of Gorkhapatra Daily, informed that Gorkhapatra has been publishing news in 42 languages to strengthen national unity.

Deputy Director-General Peng said that Nepal and China shared positive relationship since the ancient time and expressed interest in future collaboration with Gorkhapatra.

Ram Krishna Adhikari, the managerial, financial and printing advisor of Gorkhapatra Corporation, Bhimsen Thapaliya, Chief Editor of The Rising Nepal, Naradmuni Gautam, Chief Editor of Gorkhapatra Online and others were present on the occasion.



PHOTO: TRN

A Chinese delegation of media representatives led by Peng Bin, Deputy Director-General of the Publicity Department of the Communist Party of China, Yunnan Provincial Committee, posing for a photograph with Executive Chairman of the Gorkhapatra Corporation Bishnu Prasad Subedi and General Manager Lal Bahadur Airi along with others at the GC office in Kathmandu on Sunday.

Karnali govt working to attain prosperity goal

BY NABIN SUBEDI
Surkhet, Jan. 14

Chief Minister of Karnali Province Rajkumar Sharma has unveiled the details of works carried out by his government in a year.

Organising a press meet on the occasion of the completion of the first year in the office on Saturday, Chief Minister Sharma claimed that the government under his leadership has been working continuously to fulfil the dream of creating a 'prosperous Karnali and happy Karnali residents'.

"Since I took charge as Chief Minister, I had to seek a vote of confidence thrice," Sharma said, "Despite that, important works are being carried out internally." He also briefed about 31-point instructions given to employees.

According to Sharma, the government has formulated an integrated and strategic action plan based on the 31-point instructions. The plan aims to implement the government's operations in line with the expectations of the people of Karnali, the approved policy programme and budget for the year 023/024 along with the address to the provincial assembly.

He said that 13 per cent of the total budget has been spent so far with necessary amendments made to the procedure for determining the limits of multi-year contracts and ensuring expenditure.

The construction works have commenced with the contract system for large projects and although it was expected to be completed by the end of mid-November 2023, not all assigned contracts have been finished.

Minister Sharma expressed confidence that capital expenditure would improve in the second quarter as small projects are going to be controlled and regulated. He said that the decision to employ 10,000 people annually was being worked on internally. "With the vision of a prosperous Karnali and the goal of creating 10,000 jobs annually in the province, the implementation of the annual programme for the Karnali Prosperity Project is underway," he said.

He said that the Chief Minister's Employment Programme has been continued in all the wards of the municipalities with the aim of providing various employment opportunities to unemployed youth.

Road construction progress includes black-topping of 33.62 km of road, constructing 149.41 km of gravel roads, and launching 725.05 km of new track. Additionally, 51 suspension bridges and seven road bridges have been constructed.

He said that 144.20 kilometers of paved roads and canals were constructed while 622 public housing units and houses for the poor, and three community buildings were constructed.

Sharma claimed that at the end of the last fiscal year, a total of 305 projects including 87 buildings, 65 roads, five electrical structures, 30 embankments, 31 irrigations, 27 drinking water and 105 other projects were completed by the provincial government from the constituency and infrastructure special programmes.

Additional irrigation facilities were made available on 2,269 hectares of land for water resources and energy development.

He also said that clean drinking water facilities were provided to additional 103,000 people. Additionally, 152 hectares of land were developed by constructing a 13 km embankment to control the river.

Sharma also stated that in the fiscal year 2022/023, 788 irrigation schemes for small irrigation and maintenance were completed, irrigation was improved in an area of 1,500 hectares and irrigation facilities were added to 115 hectares of land.

During the construction and maintenance of the irrigation schemes, 15,220 temporary jobs equivalent to two months were created, benefiting 18,456 households.

Chief Minister Sharma said that in the year 2023/024, a total of 505 of 628 irrigation projects had been contracted and works on those projects had already started.

For the expansion of the winter fruit area, a total of 85,736 saplings including 49,800 of apples, 26,436 of walnuts, 8, 900 of kiwifruit and 600 of dragon fruit were distributed. In which 350 households have directly benefited and 250 people have received 15 days of direct employment. This programme has created full self-employment for 300 people.

Likewise, Rs. 878.3 million capital has been mobilised in the agricultural sector with an investment of Rs. 47.1 million through the interest subsidy programme.

Additionally, 4,835 households have benefited from the special target group programme, organic agriculture promotion and organic crop development programme, land rental subsidy, and agriculture and livestock business promotion programme, resulting in 947 full self-employment and 4,096 partial employment equivalent to about four months.

Minister Sharma said that 324 plastic houses were built under agriculture development promotion and road corridor programme which directly benefited 324 households.

FORMER TRN JOURNO TULADHAR PASSES AWAY



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Journalist Kamal Ratna Tuladhar died on Saturday. He was 69.

Tuladhar worked with The Rising Nepal for over a decade till 1997.

Regarded as a very talent journalist among his colleagues, he joined The Kathmandu Post after quitting TRN.

He had been suffering from heart ailment since long, he breathed his last while receiving treatment at Norvic Hospital, Thapathali, according to Bijaya Lal Shrestha, his friend and former Chief Editor of this daily.

Once a popular columnist of this daily, Tuladhar is the writer of 'Caravan to Lhasa', a travel book.

He is survived by wife and two daughters.

Seven ruling...

The election of the 19 members of the NA is scheduled for January 25.

The ruling parties have divided 19 seats among them, and 10 of the seats are given to the Nepali Congress. Likewise, six candidates from the CPN (Maoist Centre), two from the CPN (Unified Socialist) and one from the Janata Samajwadi Party- Nepal are contesting the election as the common candidates of the ruling parties.

Candidates from the Nepali Congress include Krishna Prasad Sitaula, Ananda Prasad Dhungana, Bishnu Devi Pudasaini, Jeet Jung Basnet, Kiran Babu Shrestha, Padam Bahadur Pariyar, Bishnu Kumari Sapkota, Krishna Bahadur Rokaya, Baldev Bohara and Narayan Datta Bhatta. Similarly, from the CPN (Maoist Centre), Champha Devi Karki, Shree Krishna Prasad Adhikari, Manarupa Sharma, Jhakku Prasad Subedi, Bishnu Bahadur Bishwokarma and Renu Chand are the common candidates. Ghana Shyam Rijal and Sabitri Malla from the CPN (Unified Socialist) and Puja Chaudhary from Janata Samajwadi Party Nepal are contesting the election from the ruling parties.

India's main opposition party begins a cross-country march

AP
New Delhi, Jan. 14

Thousands of members of India's main opposition Congress party and its supporters began a 2-month cross-country march Sunday in a bid to regain some of the popularity it has lost to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's ruling Hindu nationalist party ahead of a crucial national vote this year.

The march led by Rahul Gandhi, scion of the influential Gandhi family, began from the northeastern Manipur state's Thoubal district. The "Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra," or "Unite India Justice March," is scheduled to cover 6,713 kilometers (4,171 miles) in 67 days, mostly in buses but also on foot, while passing through 110 districts in 15 states, the party said in a statement.

This is the second time the Congress party has hit the road in the last two years to rally support for elections.

In late 2022, Gandhi led the "Bharat Jodo Yatra," or "Unite India March," from Kanyakumari, a coastal town on the southernmost tip of India, to Indian-controlled Kashmir. The march traversed 3,570 kilometers (2,218 miles) across 12 states in five months, and challenged the Modi government over growing economic inequality and the rising religious polarization.



India is expected to vote in a national election in April or May, and the opposition is scrambling to put up a fight against the electoral juggernaut of Modi's Bharatiya Janata Party. It remains popular after nearly a decade in power and many surveys suggest Modi will win a third consecutive term this year.

India's previously fractured opposition parties have joined hands and formed the INDIA alliance, which stands for Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance. However, it faced a setback in December when Modi's party won in three of four crucial state elections.

Modi will seek reelection at a time when India's global diplomatic reach is rising. At home he has faced a struggling economy, rising unemployment, religious tensions triggered by attacks on minority Muslims, and a shrinking space for dissent and free media.

In 2019, Modi's party won 303 out of 543 parliamentary seats, in part due to its Hindu nationalist agenda. Congress was a distant second with 52 seats.

PM asks Nepal Aushadhi Limited to produce 20 types of medicines

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has emphasised the crucial role played by Nepal Aushadhi Limited in the production of medicines.

In a meeting held at Singha Durbar on Sunday, the Prime Minister instructed for the prompt initiative to produce 20 types of medicines.

PM Prachanda held a meeting with the team led by Yagya Neupane, the Chairman of Nepal Aushadhi Limited, to discuss the pressing need for accelerating pharmaceutical production.

Acknowledging the past accomplishments of Nepal Aushadhi Limited in the pharmaceutical sector, the Prime Minister expressed concern about recent stagnation and stressed on the importance of strengthening the pharmaceutical sector.

"In the past, Nepal Aushadhi Limited has done commendable work in pharmaceutical production. I understand there has been a slowdown lately. I have called this meeting to expedite drug production in a renewed fashion. Commence the work, and the government will provide necessary assistance," said Prachanda.

"By initiating the production of 20 medicines, we aim to enhance both the quality and quantity in the future. This sector presents an opportunity for the country to achieve self-sufficiency gradually. Initiate the work, and the government will engage in further discussions with the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Industry. Let's strive to make a visible impact in this realm," added Prachanda.

During the deliberations, Chairman Neupane apprised the Prime Minister that Nepal Aushadhi Limited is currently producing 10 types of medicines, and preparations are underway for the immediate production of an additional 20 types. Neupane acknowledged challenges arising from pending financial obligations but assured that the production process would be streamlined by securing technical manpower, upgrading existing machinery, and acquiring new equipment.

Nepal Aushadhi Limited aims to meet the current demand by diversifying its product offerings. Previously known for producing 146 types of medicines, the company shifted its focus to the production of paracetamol. However, the recent plan includes diversification in production and investments to stay competitive in the market.

Chaudhary Group pays Rs. 16.14 billion in tax

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Companies running under the Chaudhary Group (CG) have collectively paid Rs. 16.14 billion in tax to the government in the last Fiscal Year 2022/23 which is 1.87 per cent of the total revenue collected by the government.

Issuing a statement on Sunday, the group claimed that the amount was the highest revenue any business group paid to the government in a year.

It also said that the contribution to the national revenue decreased in the last fiscal compared to the FY 2021/22 due to economic slowdown. Two years ago, the CG had paid Rs. 17.72 billion in taxes.

"The fact that the Chaudhary Group is able to pay high taxes even when the overall economy of the country is going through a recession and the total revenue of the government has shrunk has encouraged us. We are happy to make a significant contribution to the expansion of the national economy and the development of the nation," said Binod Chaudhary, Chairman of CG.

He also said that the Group is expanding its investment in Nepal at a rapid pace. "We believe that it will make a meaningful contribution to the national economy," he said.

Chaudhary, who is also a lawmaker, stressed that only by encouraging investors and improving the investment environment in Nepal, it is possible to widen the scope of revenue, so everyone's attention should be paid to this.

The group also said that it had paid Rs. 70 billion in taxes to the government in the last five fiscal years.

Likewise, Nirvana Chaudhary, Managing Director of the Group, said that the CG is expanding its investment by keeping Nepal as its main priority. "We are rapidly expanding investments in food and beverages, hospitality, financial sector, automobiles, education, infrastructure and new technology. We want to make an effective contribution to the overall economy of Nepal."

Although there is no practice of calculating and encouraging the contribution of business groups to the government's revenue in Nepal, Chaudhary Group has been making public the contribution of its group to the revenue every year, read the statement.

Denmark's queen is abdicating the throne

AP
Denmark, Jan. 14

Queen Margrethe II will become Denmark's first monarch to abdicate in nearly 900 years when she hands over the throne to her son, Crown Prince Frederik, on Sunday. Margrethe always maintained during her 52-year-reign that she wouldn't quit, but back surgery and other ailments left her unable to undertake as much as she could in the past. "Time takes its toll," she said, announcing her plans to abdicate in a New Year's address that stunned the kingdom.

For centuries monarchs were far more likely to die from disease or violence than to hand over titles that carried real power before the democratic era of constitutional monarchies.

But as life expectancy grows ever longer, even a schedule of symbolic duties can be exhausting in a monarch's later years. Britain's Queen Elizabeth II stuck by a commitment she made as a young woman to devote her life to service — and reigned 70 years before dying on the throne at the age of 96 in 2022.

"Abdication has become more common because people are becoming older and older," said Lars Hovbakke Sørensen, a Danish historian and lecturer. "Therefore, we have more old monarchs in Europe and (thus) older crown princes and crown princesses."

He cited as an example Britain's King Charles III who took over after his mother, Queen Elizabeth II, died when he was 74.

Here is a look at some sovereigns who have handed over their thrones to their younger and more energetic heirs in the past years.

Emperor Akihito abdicated in 2019 at the age of 85, citing age and declining health in his decision to hand over the throne to his son Emperor Naruhito. It was Japan's first abdication in two centuries.

Akihito had devoted his three-decades long reign to making amends for a war fought in his father's name while bringing the aloof monarchy closer to the people. His era was the first in Japan's modern history without war.

Akihito prepared his nation for the step by expressing a wish years earlier to abdicate while he was still well and capable. He won overwhelming public support for stepping down from a role with symbolic but no real political power, and the nation celebrated the imperial succession.

The emperor emeritus is 90 years old.

Juan Carlos I, now 86, abdicated in disgrace in 2014. He had once been so popular that many Spaniards would say that they were "not monarchists, but Juan Carlists." Those who remember him in his younger years recall the key role he played in ensuring Spain's safe transition from decades of Francisco Franco's dictatorship to a modern constitutional monarchy.

It helped that a pliant press covered up his long history of affairs and indiscretions.

His relations with the Spanish public began to crack in 2012, when the former patron of the World Wide Fund for Nature injured himself on an elephant hunting trip in Botswana while his subjects back home were living through a full-blown economic crisis.

Some Spaniards began to wonder if it was time for Spain's third republic of the past 150 years.

Bimal Baidya comes up with yet another poetry collection



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Bimal Baidya's latest poetry collection 'Yugko Tatma Ubhiyera,' was unveiled amid a programme held in Kathmandu on Saturday.

Although Baidya lives in Ilam, he has been actively contributing to enriching Nepali literature by publishing one work after another. Baidya had travelled to Kathmandu from Ilam to unveil his fourth book.

The book was jointly unveiled by poet and cultural scholar Tulsi Diwas, lyricist and essayist Ganesh Rasik, and poets Mahesh Paudyal and Momila. The book is published by Page Turner Pvt. Ltd.

The launch ceremony featured recitations of Baidya's poems by writers Rajendra Salav, Brajesh Khanal, Sneh Sayami and Prajwal Adhikari.

During the review of the collection, poets Mahesh Paudyal and Momila praised Baidya's literary creations.

Tulsi Diwas expressed that Baidya's work aims to convey a fresh message, urging poets to write not when prompted but when compelled by the circumstances.

Diwas emphasised the importance of addressing current issues and understanding what needs to be written today rather than relying solely on past themes.

He commended Bimal for infusing his lived experiences into his poetry, transforming it into a form of rebellion.

Bimal Baidya, the poet himself, highlighted his intent to portray life and contemporary situations in an artistic manner rather than merely piling words.

He shared his approach to writing about love, aiming to make it universally accessible and celebrate it artistically without being overtly explicit.

The collection of poems comprises 38 poems and marks Baidya's fourth poetry work.

The ceremony also witnessed accolades for Baidya's literary creations from lyricist and essayist Ganesh Rasik, senior journalist Kishore Nepal, and other attendees.

Gucci's new creative director plunges into menswear with slightly shimmery

AP
MILAN, Jan. 14



Hot off Taylor Swift's Golden Globe red-carpet triumph for Gucci in glittering green, the Italian brand's creative director plunged into his menswear debut on the first day of Milan Fashion Week on Friday with somewhat shimmery, slightly subversive classics.

Sabato De Sarno's second runway collection since being named creative director a year ago continued to shift and clarify Gucci codes, with several looks purposefully mirroring his September womenswear debut: a deep, blood red leather jacket over bare legs exuded passion, while a zipped navy jacket with jeans or a sheer ribbed sweater in camel spoke to the brand's urban cool. The collection was title "Ancora," Italian for still, or again.

De Sarno tended toward low-key with the silhouette and the logo: double-breasted jackets were stripped of visible closures, trenches were long and streaming, plain pea coats returned to the brand's utilitarian heritage.

The logo was sparing: Gucci was emblazoned in subtle raised letters on leather bags, the double-G logo appeared as repeating patterns on slim suits and the Gucci stripe inside coat slits. For the masses in search of a cult item: the double-G belt abides.

Bondage touches came in trailing silk ties fastened around the neck with silver hardware and half gloves in leather. The power of pairing was best displayed in a shirtless look with straight trousers, the double-G belt drifting to the hip.

With a versatile sporty-to-tailored-to-dance floor silhouette, the collection was blinged up with kaleidoscopic crystal-covered tanks or trousers, or shimmery shaggy lurex coats that mix light and motion. Zippers are deliberately deployed to catch the light against a dark palate. Crystal sequins lit up the collars of ribbed knit-wear. Adornments are purposeful, nothing overwhelming about them.

"It is manifest, and not taboo, although it might look like it should be, it is completely free, and filled with euphoria," De Sarno said in notes. In another break with the recent past, De Sarno moved the show from the modern, peripheral Gucci Hub to an industrial space in a former foundry across the city. Front-row guests included Elliot Page, and Idris Elba with his wife Sabrina Elba.

Janakpur Literature and Int'l Theatre Festival from February 1

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Janakpurdham, Jan. 14



Janakpur Literature and International Theatre Festival is scheduled from February 1 to 5 in Janakpurdham.

Organised by the Maithili Development Fund, the five-day festival aims to promote the Maithili language, literature, art, culture, economy, and tourism.

The festival is set to take place at the Mahendra Narayan Nidhi Mithila Cultural Centre in Janakpurdham, as informed by Jib Narayan Chaudhary, the chairman of the Maithili Development Fund.

The festival is planned to be divided into 20 different sessions, focusing on various issues such as politics, society, literature, and economy.

Nepali and Indian artists will be performing dramas in various languages, including Maithili, Nepali, Hindi, Assamese, and Bengali during the festival.

Featuring senior politicians from various political backgrounds, the festival highlights Mithila art, literature, theatrical performances, Maithili cultural expressions, and an array of cultural programmes.

The festival is set to showcase the involvement of academics, social advocates, creative minds, and political figures hailing from both Nepal and India. The festival aims to bring attention to conversations and exchanges surrounding federalism, language policies, diverse literary genres, and the prevailing societal conditions, said Chaudhary.

Under the Janakpur Gatha segment, organiser has planned a dedicated session to delve into the origins of Janakpurdham, explore the rich heritage of Mithila literature and art, share success stories of accomplished women from the region, and spotlights the achievements of the youth during the festival.

The Maithili Development Fund has been organising the festival every two years since 2073 BS.

The fourth edition of the festival will receive support from the Government of Madhesh Province and Janakpurdham Sub-Metropolitan City.

The organiser aims to welcome around 100,000 Nepali and Indian participants to the festival.

Selena Gomez to play Linda Ronstadt in biopic

AGENCIES
Los Angeles , Jan. 14



Selena Gomez is set to essay the role of singer Linda Ronstadt in an upcoming biopic based on her 2013 memoir titled Simple Dreams.

David O Russell, an Oscar-nominated filmmaker and writer known for American Hustle and Silver Linings Playbook, is attached to direct the upcoming film. James Keach and Ronstadt's longtime manager, John Boylan, are co-producing the biopic.

Ronstadt is a multiple Grammy winning artiste in the rock, country and Latin music space found success with albums like Heart Like a Wheel, Prisoner in Disguise and Simple Dreams' among many others.

She retired in 2011 following a progressive supranuclear palsy. Gomez, also a singer, will next star in the fourth season of Hulu's Only Murders in the Building.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Your spiritual and creative sides can support your goals now. You might have felt like you've had to rely on your logic alone for a while, but once you ponder everything, you can figure out how your intuition .

Taurus: Teaching others what you know can delight everyone involved. You might find that there are people in your midst today, whether or not you're already familiar with them, that you're able to educate.

Gemini: You may now be taking care of someone others aren't willing to handle. You're possibly saying what is on everyone's mind in order to relieve the tension or managing an uncomfortable situation to take weight.

Cancer: The people closest to you might share shocking facts about them at any moment. You may have had preconceived notions about this person, to the point that changing your mental image of them is jarring, especially if you had believed incorrect information regarding them for a long time.

Leo: Something could be missing! While you might be faced with stressful situations without warning, they are meant to alert you to whatever needs to be elevated in your life. It's possible that you're scrambling at the last second to finish.

Virgo: You might be ready to start cutting back wherever you're overdoing it. Too much of anything isn't healthy, and pretending that you're able to handle it -- whether "it" is an outside issue or an inner spiral -- isn't your best bet.

Libra: Your inner life may throw off your schedule. Sometimes you need some time to yourself, whether it's spent getting more rest, managing the turmoil of grief, or even healing from physical wounds or illnesses.

Scorpio: You might be communicating in an extra expressive way. The way that you relate to others may be rather flamboyant, which isn't bad -- but others might feel overwhelmed if you're too over the top as you deliver your news.

Sagittarius: Your inner security can have a strong reflection on your present outer life. While your intuition is likely accurate regarding new forms of revenue and investments, it may be weaker when it comes.

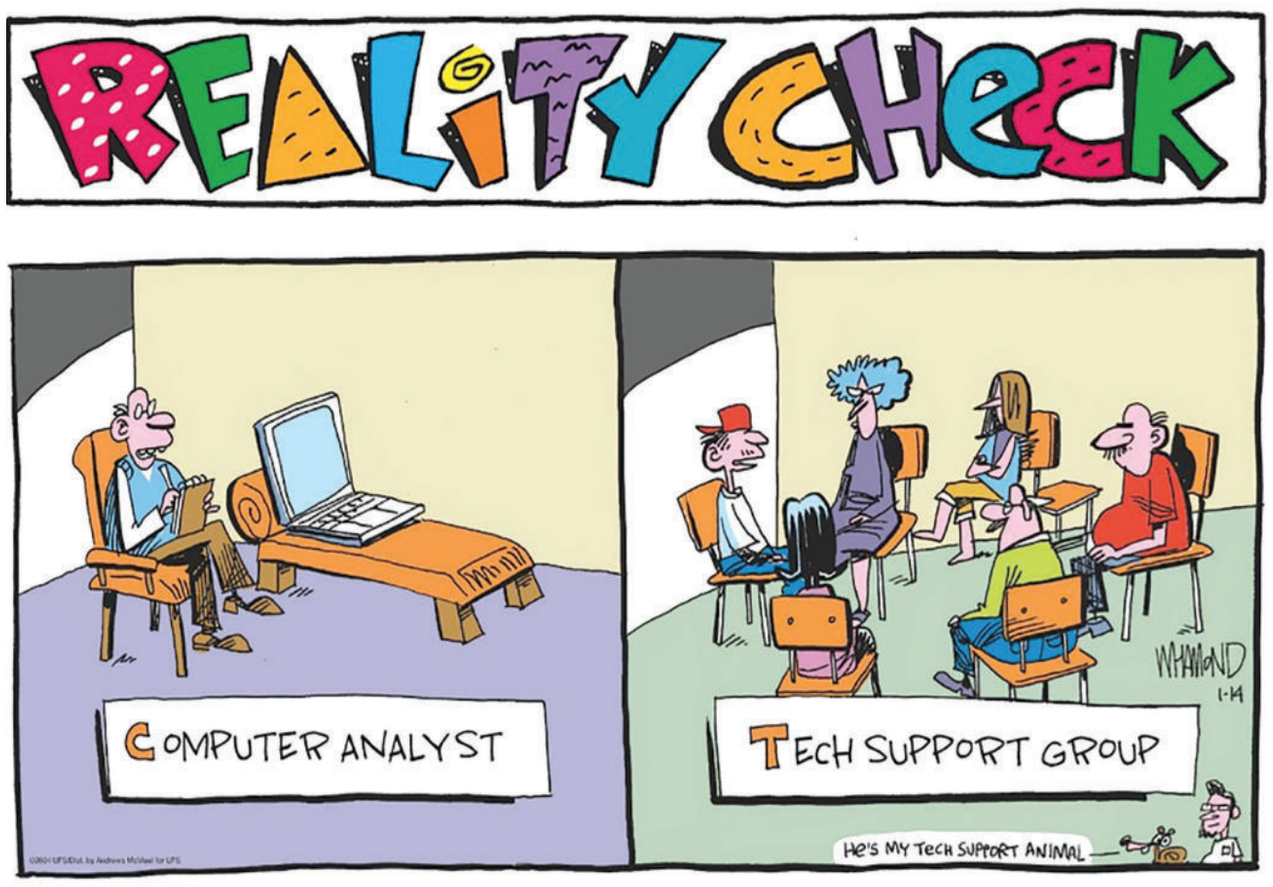
Capricorn: You can visualize a clearer idea of your future self. Knowing who you want to be starts with recognizing who you are -- and acknowledging the changes you must make to become your dream self.

Aquarius: Spiritual acceptance may provide you with more peace in your life. You currently have the ability to see reality for what it is, accept it, and then begin looking for ways to enjoy yourself more.

Pisces: Who you are in a certain group could differ from how you normally are. This is most likely to affect you in a positive and supportive way at the moment, as a community that you're spending more time.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



APF, Karnali start PM Men's Cup campaign with wins

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 14

Armed Police Force (APF) Club and Karnali Province started their campaign in the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament with wins. Gandaki lost in its first match of the tournament against Karnali while Bagmati lost its second on Sunday.

Losing to a departmental side, Nepal Police Club, on the opening day of the tournament on Saturday, Bagmati lost to another departmental team, APF Club, on Sunday.

On both days, the venue (TU International Cricket Ground) was the same and one batsman in the opponent scored a century to give a proper target to Bagmati. While Rashid Khan of Nepal Police scored a century against Bagmati on Saturday, it was Sundeep Jora on Sunday.

Bagmati elected to field first and was able to send five batsmen of APF, including captain Rohit Paudel, back to the pavilion by the 13th over. Paudel, who is also the captain of the national team, was struck leg before and departed after facing five balls and scoring two.

However, Jora, who came in at five, stood his ground until the final over. With two balls remaining for the first inning to end, Jora was run out at a score of 112 runs off 117 balls. He hit five sixes and seven fours.



PHOTO: CAN
APF's Sundeep Jora celebrates his century against Bagmati Province at the 2nd match day of the PM Men's Cup at TU International Cricket Ground, Kathmandu, on Sunday.

Lokesh Bam (27 off 42), Bhuvan Karki (10 off 18), Amar Routela (22 off 46) and Abinash Bohora (18 off 17) played a supportive inning with Jora to take the team to 241/9. On the bowling side, Bagmati's Surya Tamang took two wickets while Pratish GC and Rijan Dhakal took two each.

Bagmati's openers were troublesome to Nepal Police in the chase on Saturday. However, opener Ishan Pandey got bowled by Puran BK for a duck in the second ball he faced. Entering the pitch after the fall of the first wicket, Bagmati's captain Rit Gautam then took the helm jointly with opener Ashutosh Ghiraiya.

However, Ghiraiya, who fell short of eight runs for a century against Police, could only score 41 runs against APF.

Unable to perform with the bat, APF captain Paudel was dominant with the bowl as he took four wickets and gave only 26 runs in his spell of nine overs. Bibek Magar, who entered after Ghiraiya's wicket, was Paudel's first in the 30th over. After Magar's wicket, Bagmati was at 115.

Bagmati had some chance unless Gautam was at the crease. He raised hope after hitting a half-century but was caught in the 32nd over after scoring 60 off 89. The remaining batsmen could only add 30 more runs after Gautam left the team at 120.

Alongside four wickets by Paudel, Abinash Bohora and Mousom Dhakal took two each for APF. Puran BK and Bhuvan Karki also claimed one wicket each as Bagmati got bowled out at 152 runs in 42.5 overs.

On the other hand, Karnali won its first match beating Gandaki at Bhairahawa Cricket Ground in Rupandehi. The weather was unfavourable to start the match on time today as well. While the match was reduced to 42 overs each on Saturday, Gandaki and Karnali were given 45 overs each on Sunday.

Karnali elected to field first and proved why they decided to do so with the ball. The top five batsmen of Gandaki were either bowled or caught until the 11th over leaving the team at 22/5.

The remaining batsmen scored the remaining runs until the 45th over to take the team to 122 at the loss of nine wickets. Amrit Gurung and Kamal Pariyar both scored 21 runs for Gandaki. Anuj Chanara, Dinesh Adhikari and Dipendra Rawat bagged two wickets each while Prakash Jaishi, Diwan Pun and Rabindra Shahi claimed one each for Karnali.

Meanwhile, Karnali only lost three wickets to reach the target with 70 balls to spare. While openers Rabindra Shahi and Nischal Rawal scored 20 and 29 runs respectively, Himanshu Shahi scored a half-century for Karnali. Rawal remained not out with Arjun Gharti (10 runs off 6 balls) to score 126 runs and win the match in 33.2 overs.

Of the three wickets by Gandaki, two were taken by Ankit Neupane and the remaining one by Bipin Khatri.



PHOTO: AP
Inter Miami forward Luis Suarez, left, walks with forward Lionel Messi, center, and defender Sergio Busquets, right, during a training session for the MLS soccer team, Saturday, Jan. 13, 2024, in Fort Lauderdale, Fla.

Pakistan loses in the 2nd T20 to New Zealand in 5-match series

AP
Hamilton, Jan. 14

New Zealand overcame the loss of its captain in an innings that faltered late to beat Pakistan by 21 runs in the second Twenty20 international Sunday, taking a 2-0 lead in the five-match series.

The Black Caps failed to build on the foundation of the first half of its innings, making 194-8 batting first after being 111-1 at the end of 10 overs. The batting slump followed captain Kane Williamson retiring hurt after 10 overs with a tight hamstring.

Pakistan also stumbled in the second half of its innings and was bowled out for 173 in the 20th over.

Williamson is making a managed return from a serious knee injury and New Zealand would fear any setback to his rehabilitation. But while he didn't field, Williamson was still padded up and apparently prepared to bat at the end of the New Zealand innings.

Finn Allen's 74 from 41 balls set a cracking pace early on in the New Zealand innings. Allen put on 59 in 5.1 overs with Devon Conway (20) for the first wicket and 52 in 4.9 overs with Williamson before the Kiwi captain retired hurt on 26.

The innings began to falter at that point and New Zealand lost 3-35 between the 11th and 16th overs. Allen was out at 137-2, then Daryl Mitchell fell at 147 and Mark Chapman followed at 157 as the innings began to trend sharply downwards.

Mitchell Santner made a bright 25 before being wastefully run out as New Zealand lost its last seven wickets for 55 runs.

New Zealand was relieved Pakistan also produced an innings of two halves. It looked well on course to level the series when Babar Azam and Fakhar Zaman made half-centuries in an 87-run partnership for the third wicket.

Fakhar made 57 and was the anchor of Pakistan's innings in the first international at Auckland on Friday when the tourists fell 46 runs short in a demanding run chase.

Babar followed his 31st T20 international half-century with his 32nd Sunday, again as the bulwark of the Pakistan batting.

SNIPPETS

Bagmati Province victorious in 4th National Wado-Ryu Open Karate

Kathmandu (TRN): Bagmati Province emerged victorious in the 4th National Wado Ruy Open Karate Championship winning 10 gold medals in 12 categories of the tournament. Bagmati also won two silver and a bronze. Second-positioned Koshi Province won a gold, three silver and three bronze, followed by Madhes with a gold and five bronze. Bagmati's David Kumar Shrestha and Koshi's Sanjeeta Lepcha were adjudged the best players in the men's and women's category respectively in the two-day competition held in Basundhara, Kathmandu, on January 12 and 13. The competition was organised by Nepal Wado-Ryu Karate Do Association, and it was the first time that the karate players were awarded a cash prize.

Athletic Bilbao climbs to 3rd, Villarreal loses again

Barcelona (AP): Athletic Bilbao forward Álex Berenguer scored twice in a 2-1 win over Real Sociedad which lifted the hosts into third place in the Spanish league on Saturday. With its victory in the Basque Country derby, Athletic edged ahead of both Barcelona and Atletico Madrid. The team is on course to fight for a Champions League berth with Spain to send four, or possibly five, teams to Europe's elite competition next season. Meanwhile, Villarreal slumped to a 3-0 loss at Las Palmas in the Canary Islands, a fourth loss in five league matches that left it in 15th place. Also, Canada forward Cyle Larin scored Mallorca's first-half equalizer to cancel out an opener by Celta Vigo's Iago Aspas in a 1-1 draw. A second-half goal by Isco Alarcón in the late game gave Real Betis a 1-0 victory over Granada to move into seventh place.

Beterbiev stops Smith to retain three light-heavyweight titles

Montreal (AFP): Beterbiev, a 38-year-old Russian-born Canadian, stopped the Englishman, Smith, after two minutes of the seventh round in Quebec City, Canada, improving to 20-0 and remaining the only world champion to win every fight by early stoppage. Beterbiev retained the World Boxing Council, World Boxing Organization and International Boxing Federation light-heavyweight crowns and set the stage for a likely undisputed unification fight with unbeaten World Boxing Association champion Dmitry Bivol of Russia. Smith, a 33-year-old former WBA super middleweight champion, fell to 29-2.

His only prior defeat was by unanimous decision in 2020 to Mexican star Canelo Alvarez, the undisputed world super middleweight champion. Beterbiev, who won his first world title in 2017, defended the three titles for the second time, having stopped Britain's Anthony Yarde in the eighth round last January in London in his most recent bout.

Defending champion Djokovic fends off Prizmic to advance in Australia

AP
Melbourne, Jan. 14

Until he took on defending champion Novak Djokovic at Rod Laver Arena on opening Sunday in Australia, Dino Prizmic had never played a Grand Slam match.

The 18-year-old Croatian qualifier, who was born seven months after Djokovic made his Grand Slam debut in 2005, made it last as long as he could, unsettling the 24-time major winner at times before Djokovic finished off the match 6-2, 6-7 (5), 6-3, 6-4.

Djokovic made his Grand Slam debut at Melbourne Park in 2005 and has developed a record at the Australian Open that no man can match, with 10 titles here among his unprecedented career haul. The first set played out just about as expected. From there, it became quite a ride.

Prizmic took the second set off Djokovic and went up a break in the third, stunning a capacity crowd, before the world's No. 1-ranked player broke back and took the set.

Prizmic didn't give up when he trailed 4-0 in the fourth, either, saving a breakpoint before getting a service break back. He saved three match points at 5-3 down and made Djokovic serve it out. He then saved a further two match points before it ended in 4 hours and 1 minute.

"He deserved every applause, every credit he got tonight," Djokovic said. "Amazing performance for someone that is 18 years old and never had the experience of playing on a big stage. Kudos to him."

The first of three Sundays — an extra day was introduced at Melbourne Park to try to reduce the number of post-midnight finishes — didn't have quite the desired outcome.

Fifth-seeded Andrey Rublev needed four hours to beat Thiago Seyboth Wild 7-5, 6-4, 3-6, 4-6, 7-6 (6). He later admitted fears his first-round match against Seyboth Wild would end like his friend Daniil Medvedev's did at last year's French Open: in an upset.

No. 12 Taylor Fritz needed a medical timeout to get his left ankle taped in the second set before he recovered to beat Facundo Diaz Acosta 4-6, 6-3, 3-6, 6-2, 6-4 in a seesawing four-hour match.



Djokovic's match finished after 11 p.m., making for a late start for defending women's champion Aryna Sabalenka.

The first match on Rod Laver was over quickly, with Italy's Davis Cup star Jannik Sinner advancing after a 6-4, 7-5, 6-3 first-round win over No. 59-ranked Botic van de Zandschulp in 2 1/2 hours. It was his first match since a memorable November when he twice beat Djokovic and won the Davis Cup.

Women's eighth seed Maria Sakkari admitted her relief after she beat Nao Hibino of Japan 6-4, 6-1, her first Grand Slam win since last year's Australian Open.

Also advancing were 2021 U.S. Open finalist Leylah Fernandez, who beat 17-year-old Sara Bejlek 7-6 (5), 6-2 and No. 9 Barbora Krejcikova, who rallied from a set and a breakdown to beat Mai Hontama 2-6, 6-4, 6-3. Two 16-year-old players advanced to the second round: Brenda Fruhvirtova recorded her first Grand Slam win, overcoming Anna Bogdan 2-6, 6-4, 6-3 and Alina Korneeva — the Australian Open junior champion last year — who rallied to beat Sara Sorribes Tormo 4-6, 6-3, 6-2.

Another Russian qualifier, Maria Timofeeva had a 6-2, 6-4 win over Alize Cornet, who was appearing in a women's record 68th consecutive Grand Slam event. Timofeeva will next face 2018 champion Caroline Wozniacki, who in her first Australian Open since becoming a mom advanced when 20th-seeded Magda Linette retired while trailing 6-2, 2-0.

Amanda Anisimova continued her comeback from a career break with a 6-3, 6-4 win over No. 13-seeded Liudmila Samsonova.

Rublev did it tough, wasting four match points in the 12th game of the fifth set. He fell behind 5-2 in the match tiebreaker before regaining his composure, winning eight of the next nine points to clinch it. He slumped to the ground, then got up quickly, embraced Seyboth Wild, who was making his debut in the Australian Open main draw and roared triumphantly.

WEATHER

Monday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:30 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Monday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly regions and mainly fair in the rest of the country. Brief rain and chances of light snowfall are likely to occur at one or two places in hilly regions and mountainous regions of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province respectively.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Sunday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.0	4.5	0.0
Dipayal	23.8	5.3	0.0
Dhangadi	15.8	7.2	0.0
Birendranagar	23.0	5.2	0.0
Nepalgunj	14.8	11.2	0.0
Jumla	18.5	-5.2	0.0
Ghorahi	23.0	7.5	0.0
Pokhara	22.0	8.4	0.0
Bhairahawa	14.0	8.2	0.0
Simara	13.9	10.4	0.0
Kathmandu	19.5	5.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.0	9.2	0.0
Taplejung	18.2	5.6	0.0
Dhankuta	24.0	8.5	0.0
Biratnagar	18.7	7.6	0.0
Jomsom	13.0	0.5	0.0*
Dharan	23.0	10.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.1	6.5	0.0*
Janakpur	18.8	9.4	0.0*
Jiri	16.6	0.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 15, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.38	Rs. 132.98
Euro	1	Rs. 144.97	Rs. 145.63
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.83	Rs. 169.60
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.30	Rs. 156.01
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 88.51	Rs. 88.91
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.71	Rs. 99.16
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.41	Rs.99.86
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.14	Rs. 9.18
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.47	Rs. 18.55
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.30	Rs. 35.46
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.29	Rs. 36.46
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.79	Rs. 3.81
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.04	Rs. 36.20
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.48	Rs. 28.61
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.08	Rs. 10.12
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.87	Rs. 12.93
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.44	Rs. 19.53
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.93	Rs. 17.00
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.87	Rs. 432.82
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.14	Rs. 352.73

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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